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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting, Thursday, March 23, 2023

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=I2d0HYV0kjw
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:23:23] call the meeting to order. Welcome to the Virginia Board of Education, the hardest working board in the Commonwealth. We appreciate everybody being here. We are particularly happy today because of announcements made yesterday by the governor, including the appointment of a new superintendent of public instruction, which is, of course, essential to our work, as well as the appointment of Mr. Dale Sturdefin to the Board of Ed. Mr. Sturdefin was on the Mecklenburg County School board, which he chaired, formerly with the state police, and has got a very impressive resume, and I'm sure will do great things for the board.

[00:24:03] Dale, would you like to say a few words? I'm thankful for the opportunity to be here. For me, it's all about education, being a young kid who grew up on a dirt road in a big town called Cape Verde, Virginia, located in Southampton County, if you've never heard of it. I know the importance of education, so I've had the pleasure of talking to my fellow board members.

[00:24:25] I'm honored to be sitting here with Ms. James today, and from what I've learned pretty quickly that the board members here all have a passion about education and doing the right thing for all of our children in the Commonwealth. So I'm looking forward to working. Thank you.

[00:24:40] Thank you, and again, welcome. We are also, for those of you who don't know, the superintendent of public instruction is, by statute, the secretary of the board. Because of the vacancy in the position and the newness of the appointment, we are joined today instead on the dais by Kay Cole-James, Secretary of the Commonwealth, a person of a tremendously distinguished career, and we are honored to have you with us, Kay.

[00:25:05] So thank you. Would you like to say a few words? Only that I had the privilege of serving on this board years ago and have followed your work closely. And I want to thank our president for the tremendous work that he's done over these many years.

[00:25:26] And just to be back among so many friends and former colleagues is very important. Other than that, I'm glad to be here. Thank you. We will have a moment of silence followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

[00:25:41] Okay. First item on the agenda is approval of the minutes. I understand we have some corrections. Mr. Hanson? Not going to correct it? Oh my gosh, he's taken the doctorate without earning it. Okay. Is there a motion to approve the minutes as drafted or are there corrections?

[00:26:41] Are there corrections or amendments to be offered? Thank you. Ms. Holton, is there a second? All those in favor, signify by saying aye. Aye. Okay. We will move now to the public comment portion of the meeting.

[00:26:57] As always, we welcome input from the public. Those of you who have been here before know we limit comments to three minutes. Hopefully somebody on staff is doing that timing. Thank you. And, you know, it is the tradition of the board not to respond to specific comments from the public.

[00:27:23] However, we do ask staff to respond as appropriate. So, first up, Ms. Lucas, followed by Ms. Siddiqui. I don't see either of them, and we know both of them.

[00:27:40] Wendy Little, followed by Kathy Halverson. Tammy Say, followed by Scott Brabrand. Wow.

[00:27:58] It may be the new start time that has got people thrown. Wendy Shank-Evans and Katharina Genove. And, you know, please correct my pronunciations. I don't miss them and, you know, intentionally, and I would like to know what the correct ones are.

[00:28:15] Good morning. Good morning. Good morning, President Gecker and members of the board. States across the country are working to solve the teacher shortage crisis while simultaneously ensuring the educators who are leading classrooms have appropriate training and qualifications.

[00:28:36] the pathway proposed by arlington public schools to grant a license to individuals with a bachelor's degree and a montessori credential does both numerous montessori teachers who have other graduate degrees ranging from multiple masters to a phd have shared with me that their montessori teacher preparation was by far the hardest and most rigorous program to complete it's not a a program that individuals are going to pay for and undertake unless they specifically want to

[00:29:11] teach in a Montessori classroom. There are nine states that have a statewide pathway to teacher licensure. Of those nine, five do not require any additional coursework and two require just one three-credit course. Please note that the 10th state that was shared with you last time is Hawaii and their licensure is through a particular university. They only offer early childhood Montessori credentials, and you do not need any additional coursework on top of your credential

[00:29:47] to get a state teaching license. We recognize that the Virginia Literacy Act requires a specific course that all teachers in the state of Virginia, including those using this pathway, will need to complete. However, the methods courses are redundant and unnecessary. As you can see in the alignment that we provided prior to the last board meeting, Montessori teacher preparation thoroughly prepares teachers for methods of instruction on concepts in math, reading and literacy, science, and history and social studies. I urge you to accept the Arlington proposal and

[00:30:26] additionally require only the course mandated by the Virginia Literacy Act. APS can track any requested data to report back to the board after the first three years of implementation this pathway will enable aps to recruit the most highly qualified teachers for their montessori classroom while also freeing up conventionally trained teachers to take positions in other schools thank you so much for your time and consideration thank you i was actually remiss at the beginning of this let me just do this now i'd like to note that uh dr davis vaude is a member of the board

[00:31:04] participating remotely uh pursuant to our bylaws i have approved that participation so thank you sorry about that we're slipping up here a little bit good morning my name is katharina genovi and i'm the principal of montessori public school of arlington the only public montessori school in virginia arlington employs approximately 34 montessori teachers that have their virginia license as well as a Montessori credential at the primary and elementary level. In the 12 years

[00:31:40] I've been with APS, I have only lost one teacher to a traditional classroom, yet have transitioned several teachers into the Montessori classroom using limited resources to help fund their Montessori training. The challenges we face with staffing can be attributed to the difficulty experienced by montessori teachers when trying to obtain a virginia license i am hopeful that as a result of this board's work and recognitions of this challenges challenges the alternative pathway to montessori licensure will result in my increased ability to staff our schools

[00:32:16] in the past we have been unable to keep to open or keep open classrooms because of the challenges associated with finding candidates that have both the license and the credential i would also i would also like to request that the board recognize the rigor associated with obtaining a montessori credential that is specifically aligned to the work in the classroom in our teacher education program we learned to not only use the extensive montessori materials but also the educational philosophy that dr maria montessori envisioned for our students

[00:32:54] in addition our coursework includes anything you find in a traditional teacher preparation program such as child development individualized instruction class management and more we should require our teachers to complete only the coursework associated with the virginia literacy act and nothing more in closing i again want to thank you for recognizing this need in arlington public schools and your dedication to meeting the students needs thank you um monique O'Grady, and then I have Katharina Genove again, however, spelled differently, so can she come back

[00:33:32] again? I guess if you continue to spell your name in different ways you can come back as many times as you want. Hey everybody, I'm Monique O'Grady, a former member of the Arlington School Board. I'm going to try something different. I wrote something, I'm going to do something different. I want to start off by saying that I understand traditional education because I excelled in it. I I went to the same all-girl high school in New Orleans that our most recent female member of the Supreme Court went to and the person who runs Magic Johnson Industries.

[00:34:02] I loved it. I thought this was what I was going to do for my kids. When I had my kids, though, I put them in a Montessori preschool in Arlington, and I fell in love with it. So I say I'm a Montessori convert. I'm a convert because it works. What it does for kids, you guys, it brings three-year-olds through kindergartners together to learn in a way that entices them to keep learning, to love learning, to not worry about whether I got this first or I'm better at this because they're concentrating on learning for themselves and they're falling in love with it and they are learning it. They learn how to take that

[00:34:39] and support their friends next to them when they don't understand something. So they also learn how to be cooperative. They are able to dig in on things they care about and spend more time on things they don't understand, with manipulatives that invigorate their senses, that reach to them.

[00:34:59] And if you walk into a Montessori pre-K primary classroom, you will have three-year-olds, four-year-olds, and five-year-olds doing all these different things on their own, and you won't hear a sound in the room. It takes a Montessori-trained teacher to be able to do that. Give kids the SOL training that you require them to have and be successful.

[00:35:24] We in Arlington took that 50 years ago and turned it into success to a point that we have kids as little as three years old all the way through eighth grade doing this. And we must have Montessori teachers to do this.

[00:35:41] We are here, and I've been working on this for six years, you guys, because there is a barrier in place. And I need to ask you to please today, remove that barrier. Why? Because this is speaking to our kids and it is working. It is turning them into the employees you want them to be. And I know that because I have two employees that I birthed that came through Montessori. This is working. What is not working is this barrier. And the way that it's been brought to you, it will still be a barrier. And it's going to be a barrier for,

[00:36:20] I did the math, four one-hundredths of one percent of the public teachers in Arlington, in the whole state. Please remove this barrier. Four, four one-hundredths of one percent of the teachers. If you keep with what the panel recommended, it will not be done. I can tell you the best ways to do it, and you'll hear from my other folks in a minute. I look forward to

[00:36:53] item B. Thank you. Thank you. Dr. Corey Borgman, followed by Jonathan Hui. And we switch them because Corey's in traffic. Oh, sure. Okay. Thank you. It's like following the Beatles at Ed Sullivan

[00:37:26] show. Hi, my name is Jonathan Hui, father of Eliza and Harrison, age 97. Actually, my son just turned eight. They're currently students at the Montessori Public School of Arlington. My story begins in 2018 when my wife Katie and I had a family meeting to discuss what we should do next because our little family of four was was going out going out of our little apartment in Arlington, Virginia. And when I say family meeting, it's more like being summoned to see the CEO. As they say, I learned earlier in life that happy wife means happy life. So I took

[00:38:01] target to the discussion. We need to find a bigger space. That's what she wanted. But beyond the size of our next residence, the most important from Katie's perspective was having an education that would work for our children. As first-generation immigrants, Katie and I firmly believe education is indeed a silver bullet. But we're also fully aware that because each child is different, there is no one-side-fits-all educational path that will lead to their success in life.

[00:38:29] As we contemplated where we should call home, we thought about Arlington County, Fairfax County, and Maryland. We primarily focused on Arlington County because my daughter was already in Montessori in a pre-UK program and we wanted her and her younger sibling to have took a similar path because she was actually flourishing in it. A private Montessori program was out of our price range so as such Fairfax County was out and it was literally between Arlington County and Maryland. Ultimately Arlington County won out because of the stickiness because we already started.

[00:39:01] My daughter was already doing well in school. As such we remained this side of the Potomac River but considerably we could have gone down a different path that the public monastery option is wildly popular a mission is based on lottery and then a very long wait list my family did not actually get through through the lottery we actually had to sweat out on the waitlist clearly the public monastery program is a choice for many many parents but only enjoyed by a few in the most recent school year there was seven hundred and eighty seven applicants for 109 available space and the waitlist was 200 deep we few the

[00:39:38] happy few recognize our good fortune but seeing how my children have flourished under monastery teaching it is our hope that other families can have similar experiences in order for that to happen more seats must be made available to meet the demand from parents but you cannot have more seats available without having monastery trained teachers the board's action today can change that first and foremost by creating a pathway for virginia monastery teaching teacher licensure that does not create unnecessary barriers and obstacles by doing so you're addressing the needs of parents who have chosen the public monastery path but were rejected due to lack

[00:40:16] of availability it is within your authority to make a difference the question is will you answer the call thank you thank you sarah cruz followed by stephanie dinnan madison hawkins good morning my name is madison and i'm a junior at wakefield high school in arlington i'm here to urge you to consider granting the new AP African American Studies course to count as a history credit for

[00:40:54] high schoolers. In high school, I developed an interest in history. I liked a lot of aspects about history class, but most importantly, I like how history is multifaceted. Every moment in time has multiple sides of a story, and to me, it's fascinating to see how they differ and cause changes in society. I'm lucky enough to attend a school where there are lots of options to learn history, from AP courses like AP World and AP European History, to classes like US and Virginia government and American civilization. Last year, I decided to try something different and took African-American studies. It was an eye-opening course that will forever impact my life.

[00:41:30] I remember in fourth grade, our social studies class specifically focused on Virginian history. We learned about things like Jamestown, the American Revolution, and some of our nation's most notable presidents. In sixth and seventh grade, our nation's history was split between two years, where I learned about the pioneers on the Oregon Trail and the Roaring Twenties.

[00:41:49] this was also the important time i learned about the civil war and reconstruction i learned that the south seceded from the north and at the end of the war our nation came together again i learned a little about jim crow laws and segregation however there was always some part of me that never understood the context of various points in time it wasn't until last year i understood how these events connected there was a whole side of history i never knew about i knew about slavery but not the harlem renaissance i knew about the civil rights movement but not the great migration It is events like these that I

never truly knew until I took a course that sought to teach them specifically, when really it should have been taught all along.

[00:42:29] How could what we were taught year after year be cherry-picked when all of it is United States and Virginian history? I saw the events that occurred in the U.S. as independent developments laid out on a timeline, one after the other. I didn't understand that time was like a puzzle piece that connected to each other.

[00:42:44] In African American Studies, I started to learn how to analyze primary sources and find historical context to reach my own conclusions about our nation's truth. Next year, I've signed up to take the new AP African American Studies course, along with a few of my friends. I'm really excited because I will get to go even more in-depth about a whole new perspective of our nation's history.

[00:43:05] I want to get my hands on as many historical documents, art and music pieces, literature, and more as I can. all created by Black communities throughout time, something that has enriched our nation's culture and reflected our Constitution's ideals. I want to be able to grow up educated about what happened to our ancestors has led us to today. But most importantly, I want other students to have the same opportunity to expand their minds, which is why it's important for AP African American Studies to be counted as a history credit for high school students. Thank you. Thank you. Eric Elzinga,

[00:43:38] followed by Bruce Richardson, David Walrod, followed by Chad Stewart. Good morning. David's here. You can go. Good morning. My name is Chad Stewart and I'm an analyst with the Virginia Education Association. I'm here to address phase one of the proposed revisions to Virginia's accreditation system. We very much appreciate the note yesterday that VDOE will be reaching

[00:44:15] out to stakeholders for input over the next month and we would welcome communication with our organization which represents more than 40,000 educators throughout the state. It is our hope that changes to our accreditation system will be designed around driving student success.

[00:44:31] Functionally, we see the system doing this through incentivizing schools to focus on growth, driving resources to our highest need schools, and sharing high-value information with parents that informs their actions to better support students. In terms of determining if schools are meeting minimum state standards to be awarded accreditation status, we ask that you think critically about if your system is primarily measuring student demographics or the ability of the school to drive improvement. For nearly two decades, Virginia's not fully accredited schools have largely stayed the same. Poverty and history

[00:45:08] of state sanction segregation plays an outsized role in the predictability of what schools are accredited. In the recent accreditation year, our not fully accredited schools received less funding per student than our fully accredited schools on average. It's worth asking if a school in the neighborhood with high poverty rates and low funding is somehow able to perform far better than would be anticipated should Virginia fail them if they don't meet a metric like a raw pass rate for math or reading. The flip of that premise could be applied for a school that barely meets

[00:45:44] her accreditation standards but has very low poverty rates and is well funded. Is it worth designing a system to identify schools that are under or over performing given what might be predicted based on the local conditions. You could think about controlling for various determinants of education to better measure school performance rather than demographics and funding. I'd encourage this body to also consider how your changes to the state accreditation system may be reflected in your prescribed

revisions to the standards of quality later this year. You could recommend tying resource allocation to metrics gathered from the accreditation

[00:46:20] process. Lastly, I ask you to consider the capacity of the VDOE to support schools that do not meet full accreditation. The proposed changes for phase one would almost certainly scale the number of schools accredited with conditions. The Office of School Equality, which supports not fully accredited schools, was found in a 2020 JLARC report to be significantly understaffed. The report described the support offered to not fully accredited schools as largely a compliance exercise. The office has not received the full additional funding it requested to staff more on par with similar offices in neighboring states. Given this reality,

[00:46:57] ask you to consider how an office that's currently understaffed would be able to meaningfully support a large number of new fully accredited schools and if it would be better to shrink their scope i thank you for your time and i'll leave extended comment comments with additional context um with megan thank you uh chris jones followed by ann tatis morning morning morning president gecker vice president man members of the board madam secretary my name is chris jones and i am the

[00:47:33] executive director of the virginia affiliate of ascd i am dad to four of virginia's public school students and prior to serving vascd i was a high school principal thank you for allowing me to stand before you today it is an honor to do so i'm here to speak briefly on two items for which vascd is positioned and willing to help the accountability system and the virginia literacy act on february 28th i submitted a brief to you on considerations for the future of assessment and accountability in Virginia. In it, our first and most important consideration is to spend the necessary time developing a unified purpose of accountability. The purpose will drive decisions

[00:48:10] to make the system do what you intended to do. The board would also benefit from spending the requisite time to develop a shared purpose of education itself. Your defined purpose of education will drive your decisions for the indicators within the accountability system you co-construct diving directly into the weeds before dedicating the necessary time on a unifying purpose made progress we saw a little of that happen yesterday during your work session i urge you to spend sufficient time landing on the purpose of education and the purpose of accountability before taking any steps further va scd stands ready to facilitate that conversation and we

[00:48:48] stand ready to lead facilitate and support any of the work associated with constructing the system through this body as well as the HB 585 work group to modernize assessment. Finally, I want to ensure this board hears directly from me that BASED is positioned and fully capable to carry out the micro-credential requirements in the Virginia Literacy Act. I heard Delegate Coyner during yesterday's session mention her worry point. We are ready and willing to take on the work. Thank you.

[00:49:17] thank you uh and tatis uh and now christy let's see that that is the entire list um let me ask is there anybody who had not signed up who would like an opportunity to address the board i'm happy to hear from you i don't see anybody so we're gonna uh i can't see around that corner though either no okay so we will close public comment thank you all for being with us i will

[00:49:52] say that i do think we ought to build happy wife happy life into one of the standards of learning somewhere got to be a topic that that fits in okay on to the consent agenda uh final review to certify a list of qualified persons for the office of division of superintendent of schools is there a motion to approve uh the consent agenda mr president yes we're just mentioning to approve the agenda the consent agenda

which is just the certification the only item on it is the superintendent certification may i make a comment about the superintendent certification

[00:50:29] um i just wanted to say that i am so honored that my mentee um when i was in the classroom still at goochland middle school is applying and on this list for their superintendent's license so it is a really proud moment for me to see him on this list michael jarvis and um it's just really exciting so thank you great okay is there a motion to approve the consent agenda thank you

[00:51:02] miss creasy any second thank you mr rotherham all in favor signify by saying aye item b final review of arlington county public schools alternate route to licensure for certain endorsements pursuant to house bill 2486 um miss johnson miss clemens is it just you it was not supposed to be

[00:51:35] well welcome i will say my meeting notes indicated miss johnson but dr johnson okay are we prepared to go with just you maggie okay thank you uh good morning um members of the board i'm secretary my

[00:52:13] name is maggie clemens i'm the director of licensure and school leadership and joan johnson is our assistant superintendent for teacher education at licensure yep good morning good morning good morning president gecker and board members especially our new members welcome i'm dr johnson assistant superintendent of teacher ed in licensure we bring before you today and for final review of the arlington county public schools arlington route to licensure for for certain endorsements pursuant to House Bill 2486

[00:52:49] of the 2019 Virginia General Assembly. As you may remember, the Commonwealth has three key pathways to becoming a licensed teacher, approved teacher preparation programs, reciprocity, and alternate routes. Specifically, regarding alternate routes, the Board of Education's licensure regulations for school personnel provide multiple alternate routes, which you have in the agenda, including career switcher, et cetera.

[00:53:14] And included in that list now is the House Bill 2486, which is a little unique. Today, I hope to briefly summarize the item and bring to your attention new information requested during the first review. This item highlights again House Bill 2486 and implementation of the bill, the board's approved guidelines, which establish a process to permit a school board or any organization sponsored by a school board petition the board for approval of an alternate route to licensure pursuant to those guidelines

[00:53:49] and in alignment with the competencies outlined in approved program regulations arlington public schools submitted an application for an alternate route to licensure for their division specifically a zps is seeking an alternate route to virginia professional educator license for montessori licensed teachers in early primary ed, elementary, and middle school education.

[00:54:15] Per the guidelines, the Virginia Department of Ed formed a panel of educational leaders to review ACPS's application, and you see that in attachment A, to determine the competencies of the respective endorsements aligned with the competencies set forth and the approved program regulations, as well as aligned with existing licenses.

[00:54:38] such the panel recommended minor modifications to the application to strengthen the proposed alternate route preparation the panel recognized the vigor of the program and the training of the montessori teachers as well as the demand in arlington but yet found deficiency specifically around areas related to virginia sol's various virginia specifics versus the the national preparation that is received

by the Montessori teachers and again the panel is presenting recommendations and guidelines that you see in your packet there specific to the various endorsements

[00:55:16] uh i won't highlight or won't go through each you see them there i think it's on about page 10 in the item which highlights specific methods as well as various competencies and requirements specifically related to the implementation of the la in the commonwealth as well as the assessments if individuals do not already have that. Ultimately, those will receive a provisional license and have the normal time to address these outstanding conditions. Ultimately, they will receive a provisional license and may be issued the 10-year renewable license with the endorsement in respective areas upon completion of those being satisfied.

[00:55:54] Then I'll bring to your attention the new information, which was also highlighted, I believe, from our public comment period. But as requested by the board, again, you should find a graphic in attachment c outlining as well as a narrative starting on page 11 of existing state policies and practices of at least 10 states that offer an alternate route to licensure for public educators who hold the Montessori credential and again that's highlighted in the graphic attachment c as well as the narrative and highlighting just collaborating with our public comment for you all of those 10 states those individuals who hold a national monitoring

[00:56:31] credential. Six states have additional coursework assessments and or professional studies. Three states require an additional assessment and one state does have or what we would describe as a one-for-one. Eight of those states allow for their teachers to teach in public Montessori schools only, while two of the states have no restrictions regarding the school employment. It's important to note that one state, Ohio, allows for individuals following this path to be licensed for teaching in specifically Montessori schools only during the provisional period and then once all of the requirements are completed the full renewable license that is issued allows the individual to

[00:57:08] teach in any school in the division also new we tried and attempted to summarize the discussion from the board during the first review as well and you see that highlighted specifically board members were reminded of the guidelines offer an alternate route to licensure but do not provide a new license be created. Hence, the panel was directed and focused on looking at the alignment with the regulations as well as the existing licenses in the commonwealth issued by the board.

[00:57:40] Also, during the meeting, the board members inquired if there were additional options for the Montessori program that may be considered during their first review. The item on review is for approval of an alternate route to existing licenses. The existing licenses of the collegiate professional and the postgraduate professional license, as well as the endorsements for elementary and middle school currently have no restrictions. It is at the discretion of the board, as we discussed, to create licenses or endorsements that may have restrictions. However, that creation is subject to the rulemaking requirements of the administrative process, as well as the discretion

[00:58:15] of the board today to accept the panel's recommendations or not. We also add some considerations there in terms of logistics and implementations, if that decision is made, that creating the license or endorsements with restrictions requires significant development with our licensure database and revisions to data reporting in collaboration with the Office of Data Services. Again, just all for your consideration. And then finally, there was no change in the superintendent's recommendation. The

superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board approve the recommendations of the department's panel regarding the petition for the alternate route.

[00:58:52] I'll be glad to entertain any questions. And I have, thank you, our director of licensure, Maggie Clemens, with me as well. Yeah, I think what we're going to do first, AG's office and the board need to discuss a few legal issues surrounding the statute.

[00:59:09] And therefore, I'm going to ask for a motion to move to executive session for the purpose of receiving legal advice. And rather than have people leave this room, has been the tradition the board is actually going to leave and go up to the conference room on 25 in order to you all can stay here and we will adjourn up there if there is a motion and a second that passes thank you miss creasy thank you dr man all those in favor signify by saying hi oh you got you got the official noble council's going to tell me the short form motion wouldn't

[00:59:47] Mr. President, I move that pursuant to Virginia Code 2.2-3711-A40, the Virginia Board of Education convene in a closed meeting for the purpose of consultation.

[01:00:09] A-8. Sorry. A-8. Excuse me. Gave me the wrong one. Convenient a closed meeting for the purpose of consultation with legal counsel regarding agenda item B pursuant to 2.23711A8. And that Deb Love and Abigail Gump, legal counsel to the Virginia Board of Education, as well as the following staff members, Kimberly Ritchie, Melissa Velasquez, and Jim Chapman, whose presence will aid the board in consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting

[01:00:45] the motion is there a second second all those in favor signify by saying aye aye we will adjourn

[01:00:51] one on adjourn we will move into closed session but y'all please stay and be comfortable today in

[01:36:20] a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above in accordance with the freedom of information act section 2.2-3712 of the code of virginia requires that the board certify to the best of each member's knowledge only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter and only such public business matters were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard discussed or considered any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote indicating the substance or of the departure that in his or her judgment has taken place

[01:36:59] the statement of the departure shall be recorded in the minutes. Thank you. We'll do the certification by roll call. Ms. Creasy? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Dr. Mann? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Mr. Certifin? Aye.

[01:37:14] Ms. Davis-Vaught? Aye. Thank you. And Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Okay. So we are back and we are still on item B. Ms. Johnson or Dr. Johnson, excuse me. No, it's not okay. Yes, I'm available for any

[01:37:37] questions or follow-up? Board have any questions? Thank you. Ms. Johnson, this application did not go through ABTEL, and that's because our guidelines do not require it. Is that correct?

[01:38:05] That's correct. For this house bill, that's correct. But if there are changes to the legislation or regulations or types of licenses, those would go through ABTEL. so the difference seems to the main difference in what we're hearing here seems to be whether we require the three additional courses or the one additional course uh in my mind uh just speaking

[01:38:39] for myself the montessori proponents seem to have made a pretty strong case that the one additional course is worth a worthy experiment shall we say what do you have want to help me the other two courses that the panel is recommending you want to help me understand what am i missing about why those would be important again um we're open to the board's guidance and direction the panel was given specifics in terms of comparing the proposal with the approved program regulation competencies

[01:39:14] as well as guidance around the existing licenses that we have in the commonwealth and encouraged to think or think futuristically about the needs for the VLA implementation. So I don't think you're missing anything, but again, the methods courses were there because those were specifically related to Virginia standards and methodologies.

[01:39:36] Mr. President, prior to serving on this board, I had the opportunity to serve on a panel, expertly facilitated by Maggie Clemons, to look at another division and an alternate pathway.

[01:39:52] But that was under a different provision. So my question would be, the rules that we used for that process that we used were pretty clearly laid out and measured and used by the panel. Again, a voluntary process of people throughout the Commonwealth.

[01:40:11] The rules for this were laid out in a similar manner. How is this process different from the one that we've already approved? Maggie, would you like to respond?

[01:40:27] So, you participated in a panel for a alternate pathway under the current regulations. That pathway was specific to professional studies. So, those are those, the professional studies, 18 hours, semester hours of, you know, your human growth and development, your foundations, the pedagogy that's set together.

[01:40:51] This one is different because under House Bill 2486, it allows for content as well as professional studies and assessment. So it kind of glumps everything together. And so the panel, it's the exact same process for the panel that you participated in and the panel that we did for the Bonasori.

[01:41:10] The difference here is that when we went to look at the content, because, again, the one that you sat on didn't have the content, went to look at the content um those methods classes the panels didn't feel like the competencies of those methods classes were being met by the montessori curriculum because again those methods classes are part of the approved program competencies for virginia and the montessori um was on the national scale you know type of thing and montessori is a methods um you know

[01:41:42] methods rather than what you would have the other content any other questions okay is there a motion on this item or any discussion i guess i do have an extra question so the guidelines outline that this is a three-year look back there's a three-year check so guidelines outline that we may impose that the current proposal before the board does not include that i mean i i would like to include

[01:42:17] that but it's not there today yeah i think that that would be my question i i really have been advocating for decades for innovation experimentation but um i think the plan do study act cycle requires that after you innovate you come back and you look at it from my understanding it is there as well as any other requirements for arlington public schools teachers evaluations all those things would be the same because they're part of arlington public school so the requirements for teacher evaluation cycles all those things would be the same i think what we're saying is that the alternate path for licensure right now would terminate in three they'd have to come back

[01:42:54] before the board to extend it so that we could study what happened yes and just given the precedent here. I think if we get annual data, I'm not asking them to collect anything they don't already collect, but just to help us as a descriptive matter so we know what's happening.

[01:43:11] What kind of data might you think about? Are you talking about outcomes regarding children? I'm thinking more slippage people who are leaving. I'm inclined to take Arlington at their word i have no reason i have no reason to disbelieve them but this is also you know you know as a as a former president said trust but verify like this will be good data for us particularly as other folks uh um come along and and so that anything they can give us an evaluation i certainly we don't want to create a paper chase we don't want them to collect new data but they collect a fair amount that would just be useful for us to know i mean i tend to be very much in

[01:43:50] favor of maximum flexibility on things like this i think there's a lot of evidence to support giving maximum flexibility but like it's a learning process for us so i'll take a stab at a motion just to get it started if you would like i i move that we grant the application request from arlington county with the panel's recommendations except that we require only the vla literacy course

[01:44:23] and not the two other courses that the panel methods pretty much the methods so not the methods courses in addition that would be time limited to three years at this point that data be collected with regard to teacher retention in arlington uh but i'm assuming at this point you're not looking to restrict to arlington only in terms of where they can teach that's my motion there's a friendly amendment teacher teacher retention and evaluation data sure that's fine i'll second does that all make sense attention all second somebody who's taking the minutes is that make is that sufficient

[01:44:59] for the minutes okay thank you we have a second thank you uh all those in favor signify by saying aye aye aye any opposed nay okay that carries thank you all right mr president can i just add a comment of joan before we lose joan and maggie i do think as the board's liaison to abtel i had not realized when we adopted these guidelines that we did not gain the benefit of abtel's

[01:45:38] expertise on these matters and rec if i'm correct in understanding that we've got a bunch of future applications learning from this first one that came through pursuant to this statute i would like to ask that we explore the possibility if if we can send it through abtel without unduly slowing things down um um and i i don't know that we i'm not suggesting we decide that today there but that we ask the staff to explore do we have to go back and formally change the guidelines or can we just ask that abtel weigh in or anyway can we i just like to flag for future discussion the

[01:46:17] potential that we use abtel's expertise on these applications that's fine if dr johnson and miss clements if you could take a look at that and uh deal with mr chapman with regard to the guidelines and see what we'd have to do to make that change occur not presuming that we would no no bring it back to the help us think it for a discussion item thank you uh and i'd like to particularly thank the people who came down from arlington the number of times uh and personally if you see uh you know your council i'd like you to thank her we you know she was very helpful to

[01:46:51] me as we went through this process okay uh item c let me just ask since uh before you go mr chapman uh how many folks came thinking the meeting started at nine and wanted to make public comment well no jim oh sorry no please i'm just going to submit mine written thanks

[01:47:32] i don't think we're deceptive however i would like uh with the board's indulgence to just reopen public comment for a brief time in order to uh hear the folks who you know came um i believe miss lucas you are first on the list we're gonna do it now good afternoon thank you for making this accommodation we were not notified properly by this board that your meeting started at 8 a.m and it is quite a hardship on the public to change your meeting in such a manner where individuals

[01:48:11] especially mothers and fathers that take their children to school are not able to come but i believe that's intentional once again my name is candace flukas i am a licensed educator licensed administrator unlike the individual that is running special education i earned my administrative license the right way. It wasn't given to me, and it's not restricted, okay? I want to make sure that you know that Samantha Hollins, her administrative license is restricted, yet she's running special education for the entire state and can't even be a building principal. So once again, you guys have

[01:48:47] some issues. I've been coming to the Board of Education since Ann, you were secretary. I don't looking but i have been okay and my issue is that you guys continue your job as the board of education is to enforce essa that's on your website every student succeeds at every student is not succeeding in virginia under section j of essa you're supposed to address the issue of special education and make sure that it's being implemented properly you're not doing that instead of using school

[01:49:22] improvement plans money to pay sans anderson two hundred thousand dollars in powertan we should be using school improvement money to teach our kids how to read and provide one-on-one supports for them the board of education is not providing the oversight supervision nor are you providing the ethical moral and legal oversight to protect our children i don't know how many times i have to to come here and say it. The DOE has told the Virginia Department of Education, you all notice in a year, get yourselves together. We've been saying it for 10 years that they

[01:49:59] need to get themselves together. I want to know on this board, when will children with disabilities, when will children of color, when will children that speak English as a second language, be your children? I want to know, when will they be your children? When will you fight for them? When will you remove incompetent leaders? When will you remove and make legislation and policies to make sure that school divisions are not misallocating special education money to shareholders in private law firms? You don't

[01:50:38] want money to go to private schools, but you're okay with money going to a private law firm for their shareholders, this cannot go on. Our children are dying. Virginia was number three in the nation for referring Black male students with disabilities to the school to prison pipeline, preschool, because in Henrico, as your report indicated, children that were three years old were being suspended 60 times on average.

[01:51:06] So we have to take some action. There is a crisis in Virginia regarding students with disabilities. - Thank you, Ms. Lucas. siddiqui wendy little kathy halverson hammy c oops good morning good morning board i'm here once again to speak on behalf of my son alexander halverson from powhatan county as you know i've been coming back here um he's still out of school since november 10th 2021 this is a child that

[01:51:45] loves school he's once again still crying every night to go to school and he cannot go to school because Powhatan keeps continuing to state that I have to mandatory sign a CSA consent that is invalid totally invalid I contacted the board about for y'all to send a contract Samantha Hollins notified me September 21st 2022 that you do not have the authority to approve this contract

[01:52:18] as requested completely false code number 22.1-214 number e states that the board can issue a contract or funding if all else has been done properly through the school division i have done that i went through due process miss lee ruled private placement my son is still out of school you can withhold the money from special education from Powhatan County and send my son to school or

[01:52:54] send a contract for my son to go to school. Then I received, I asked for the December 1 count. The December 1 count, last year and this year, Powhatan County received money to educate my child.

[01:53:13] He still has not been educated. He was on home base. No teacher ever showed up. Samantha Hollins once again stated she doesn't have the data. Who does the audits? They received money to educate my child. I'm a taxpayer. They have not done that. I asked Samantha Hollins what regulation she has to disclose over 600 emails about my son's PII. She sends me, oh, everything's safe. That's not

[01:53:48] what I was asking. I want the regulation that states how she has permission to disclose my son's PII to John Eisenberg and others. Now back to the consent. They state they don't have funding for my son. You have a copy. Improvement of instruction from federal money, Powhatan County.

[01:54:15] every single dime highlighted legal services they are over 730 percent of their budget for legal services but my son cannot go to school and I'm almost finished the consent the CSA consent I have

[01:54:43] Lynn Prince she's at the board stating that I do not have to sign a CSA consent that they are responsible for payment so when will the board step up and send a contract and send my son to school. Thank you. Tammy C. Good morning. Good morning, board. My name is Tammy C. It's my first

[01:55:21] time speaking. My son is 19 years old. He's a student of Palten County. How is everyone feeling this morning? Are y'all feeling successful and accomplished? Because my son, he's special needs.

[01:55:37] He's in Palten County and he doesn't. He feels worthless because y'all failed him. So y'all have this policy. No child left behind. Wow, that's interesting because Powtan has been doing that for years. My brother, he graduated in 1997. Can barely read and write on a first grade level.

[01:56:02] So like I said, it's been going on in Powtan for a very, very long time. I had no clue that I was the main voice in the IEP because all the IEPs come predetermined. I begged and begged for my son to have further testing because I knew it was more than ADHD. So anyways, on to the next subject here.

[01:56:32] So they basically refused to do any further testing. So I sought out a neuropsychologist, Dr. Kawaja, to test him further and found out that he is definitely on the autism spectrum. So now Patton County wants to practice medicine without a license. Does that sound familiar?

[01:56:56] Yes, they want another IEE because the neuropsychologist that I got isn't enough. I don't trust anything they would do concerning an IEE because everyone seems to be connected somehow in this county.

[01:57:16] Now, currently going on two and a half years of studying for his GED with zero accommodations put in place at this time, They're receiving money for him to go to school for a whopping hour and 15 minutes a day. Why? Simply because they can't provide a teacher longer than that time frame in a small setting.

[01:57:39] He goes to a trailer. He does not even enter the school premises of the school. He goes into the trailer right outside the school for a whole hour and 15 minutes. And yes, they're in fraud. They've committed fraud because on the December 1 count, they're claiming him.

[01:57:58] he's getting, they're getting money for free lunches. My son don't even enter the actual building to get a lunch, but they're getting, they're getting money. So, and then they're supposed to start like an intervention plan at age 14. Well, I had to seek out DARS myself to hopefully get him to feeling successful. So, and I got that approved last summer. So, we're working on that you know and so he don't end up on disability for the rest of his life

[01:58:34] and then maybe he can possibly feel successful and accomplished like each and every one of y'all thank you very much students aren't you know so and basically i've got a few more things no ma'am your time is up i'm sorry okay well the school system has failed him and y'all look beautiful in y'all's colors and virginia needs to change unless y'all want to be wearing a whole lot of orange

[01:59:02] changing scott braebrand please good morning i'm scott braebrand executive director for the virginia association of school superintendents uh dear board of education members and secretary cole james first i want to thank former state superintendent jillian balo for her service to the commonwealth VAS pledges to work collaboratively and cooperatively with Lisa Coons, the next state superintendent,

[01:59:37] and with Jeremy Raley, the next chief of staff for the Virginia Department of Education. We have also deeply appreciated the communication during this transition from Secretary Gadara. We fully appreciate the beginning of the conversation you began yesterday around accreditation and accountability and look forward to being fully engaged with you in this very important process. We completely support the current recommendation to remove chronic absenteeism from the current accreditation framework. We also want to reaffirm the importance of incorporating

[02:00:15] student academic growth in any final accountability system. We also appreciate you continuing to see feedback around the Commonwealth on social studies standards and that you will follow, as we have asked for before, standard processes and protocols to fully engage all Virginians on this very important issue. Our vast conference next month will focus on the Virginia Literacy Act, mental health, and legal issues, and we have many members of the senior leadership from the Virginia Department of Education coming to present as panelists and presenters. We have also already

[02:00:51] invited Superintendent Coons and Chief of Staff Dr. Raley to our conference to bring greetings and opening remarks and share their thoughts as we move forward together. Finally, I just want to mention we're going to announce our state superintendent of the year at the conference and our region finalists include amy cashwell in region one from henrico chris holland and region two from acomac county uh sarah calverick from caroline county in region three region four jason van hukulum from winchester region five bobby johnson from campbell county region six uh verleta

[02:01:28] white from roanoke city region seven rob graham from radford and region eight chip jones we're looking forward to of course celebrating them and selecting a state superintendent of the year in this time of transition vast reaffirms its commitment to the students and families and communities in our commonwealth to provide the best public education possible and maximize the potential of every child we look forward to continuing to work with you during this transition

[02:01:56] thank you very much thank you uh sarah cruz hi good morning president gecker dr man members of the board my name is sarah cruz and i am the english language arts supervisor for arlington public schools today i would like to share with you about the steps our district has taken to align our practices with the science of reading as laid out in the virginia literacy act to include implementation of a high quality instructional resource aps is of one accord

[02:02:32] with the state of virginia and that we seek to ensure all children read it benchmark in k-3 and to provide teachers with evidence-based instructional strategies and curricula. In Arlington, our leadership prioritizes literacy for our division.

[02:02:47] Dr. Duran and our cabinet made sure we had the funding to seek the resources needed. We partnered with many stakeholders to include our parent advisory committee. The committee selected Core Knowledge Language Arts, or also known as CKLA. CKLA is a rich knowledge building curriculum that is designed to build a child's understanding of history science literature and the arts having deep background knowledge and vocabulary about many topics is what makes reading comprehension possible and the image explaining this is included in your packet called the reading rope so after we ordered the ckla materials over this

[02:03:25] past summer we waited for the trucks to arrive at our schoolhouses and then we filled our classrooms with readers and activity books that contain knowledge of literature like the wind in the willows and don quixote rich science content such as cycles of nature the human body systems and astronomy it even includes history content such as greek myths empires in the middle ages and the renaissance now if you've ever asked a group of people to change how they are doing something you know just how easy that is while waiting for the materials we prepared the soil by sharing with each school site about the new materials and asked how they wanted to participate in the

[02:04:04] training. Once the materials arrived, training sessions lasted from July to October. All this effort is worth it when I walk into a third grade at Tuckahoe Elementary and I see students writing an opinion essay on Julius Caesar. Was he a hero or a traitor? Or I move over to Innovation Elementary and I see a kindergarten class learning words like botanist and crops as they talk about George Washington Carver and his study of plants. Then I visit Glebe Elementary and I see first graders discussing astronomy and naming the constellations. As I visited Fleet Elementary, the second grade

[02:04:41] class there was studying insects. The students were learning how to explain the difference between social and solitary insects. Each of these rich and engaging topics are units within CKLA. This is our first year of implementation with Core Knowledge Language Arts. We know we have much to learn. But this curriculum will move literacy proficiency forward in APS. And I urge the board to be sure it is included in the approved resources for the Virginia Literacy Act for all of Virginia.

[02:05:10] Thank you. Thank you. And please give my best to Dr. Duran. Stephanie Dinnan, Eric Elzinga,

[02:05:27] Bruce Richardson, David Walrod, and Tatis. Good morning. First, I'd like to start out if there's anybody in the room under the age of 18 or watching on tv that if you would please excuse

[02:06:02] your child or excuse yourself from the room and i'm really tired of hearing about this book banning myth um as if it's something that's an option because if you didn't know virginia has no exemptions allowing it what does this mean is that exemptions of the application of the obscenity 23 pages okay it all is fine so nothing in this article shall be construed to apply to purchase distribution distribution exhibition loan of any book magazine printed manuscript material by any

[02:06:34] library school or institution of higher education all three exemptions are all and if you guys unless you learned common core english or common core literacy that would make sense that everything before is included in of higher education. What it looks like in other states is where there are clear legal

defenses to remove primary and secondary schools from being. Virginia is not one of them, so why is this even a debate? What does this look like, okay? What this looks like

[02:07:08] in Chesterfield County is, this is from our high schools, vulva, how girls should masturbate. in this book. Let's talk about it. Butt plugs. How to get anal pleasure. Chesterfield County in our high schools. This is clearly if you walk up to a child on the street and handed this to them, you would be arrested for what? Many. And you'd be a felon. You could call the police. But this is allowed in our children's schools. And people want to talk about book banning. They're criminals, period. There's no law allowing it. A great place to research fantasies and kinks

[02:07:47] Safely is on the internet. There's tons of people and communities out there who share your interest and have all kinds of advice. But depending your age and where you found out, porn can also be unethical and legally watched. So do your research. There's pages and pages of this and positions.

[02:08:06] This one is in our middle schools. It's perfectly normal. The same thing. Sex positions, making love. This is all obscene under the law of Virginia. Who's going to do something about this? Who's going going to save the children who are, this is sexually graphic material. You simply have to look up and think that once children are exposed to this, it never leaves their tiny brains. So if you're the Virginia Department of Education, because I don't think you're the Virginia Department of Knowledge, because that would sound totally dystopian. You're not the Virginia Department of Labor or Workforce, or are you? You're the Virginia Department of Education,

[02:08:44] not federal education. Your job is oversight. It is, why do I have a uni party? Because both parties have the same workforce-driven education and have for years from Governor Wilder with outcomes-based education, which brings in Mr. Rotterdam over here. I have the joy of researching him and Podesta, and that brings in Ms. Kane over here, who ran your husband and Hillary. So, you've got no child left behind. You've got ESEA. You've got ESSA. That's your time.

[02:09:13] And I'll close real quick with, um, so then there are going to take the United States. And so we're going to figure this out. So that would be our governor at World Economic Forum 2020 talking about the jobs they don't have openings for.

[02:09:29] And we're going to figure this out. And how are you figuring it out with our children? Our children's job is not to fulfill the jobs you perceive they might have in the Fourth Industrial Revolution. Okay. Final speaker, Christy.

[02:09:48] All right, we will once again close public comment and move on to item C, first and final review of requests from Buena Vista City Public Schools to discontinue a local graduation requirement. Mr. Chapman, thank you. President Gecker, Vice President Mann, members of the board, Secretary James, good morning. This item before you is the result of a request from Buena Vista

[02:10:23] Public Schools. As you're well aware, the statutes governing public schools in Virginia, specifically the standards of quality, require that each local school board award a diploma to secondary school students, including students who transfer from non-public schools or from home instruction, who meet the requirements prescribed by the board and meet other such requirements as may be prescribed by the local school board and approved by this board.

[02:10:49] In addition, your regulations in the standards of accreditation section 51 specify that additional requirements prescribed by local school boards that have been approved by this board will remain in

effect until such time as the local school board submits a request to this board to amend or discontinue that local graduation requirement. In June 2018, the Board of Education approved a request to add a local graduation requirement from Buena Vista City Public Schools. The request was to require all ninth grade students to take information technology fundamentals,

[02:11:27] unless an iep team determined otherwise the course would not be required for transferring students and students could choose to use the it fundamentals course as an elective to satisfy the requirements of the standard or the advanced studies diploma buna vista is now requesting that the board approve discontinuing this local graduation requirement beginning with the 23 24 school year over the four years that the local graduation requirement has been in place buna vista has found that not all students have an interest in the it fundamentals course and they they feel they're being forced to take it. In 2019 and 2020, the student failure rate for the course

[02:12:03] was 22 percent. In 2020-2021, failure rate was 27.5 percent. In 2021-22, the failure rate was 14 percent. And through the first semester of the current year, the failure rate is 28 percent. By contrast, data from the CTE Annual Performance Report indicates a 97 percent pass rate.

[02:12:23] Buena Vista has found that requiring all students to take the course in ninth grade, regardless of interest is negatively impacting enrollment in other business and information technology courses. This year, they didn't have enough interest in their AP computer science or computer information systems in order to offer the course. And when they asked students why they hadn't signed up, a number of them specifically cited that the I2T fundamentals course was too hard.

[02:12:48] Punivist has also found that by requiring this as a local graduation requirement, the course cannot be counted toward the completer course toward the business and information technologies pathway, and they feel their students are at a disadvantage to schedule and complete the two different sequences. So they are, of course, requesting at this point that the board allow them to discontinue this use for those reasons. Okay, thank you. Any questions by board members? If not, is there, we are being asked to waive first review and move to final action. Is there a motion to approve this request or to the contrary? Thank you, Dr. Mann. Is there a second

[02:13:28] to the motion? Second. Thank you, Mr. Sturfen. All those in favor, indicate by saying aye. Aye. Any opposed? That carries. Thank you, Mr. Chapman. Thank you. First review of alternative accreditation plans. Item D, Ms. Sipka, good morning. Loving Ryder, also good morning. You were not shown on

[02:14:07] my list, but I'm very happy to see you. Good morning, President Gecker, Vice President Mann, and board members. Today I will present the first review of applications for alternative accreditation plans for the 23-24 accountability year. Based on authority granted in the standards of accreditation, local school boards of special purpose schools can seek approval for an alternative accreditation plan from the State Board of Education. This year, six local school boards

[02:14:45] have submitted applications for a total of 11 schools the school divisions and schools are shown on the screen arlington chesterfield danville fairfax loudon and richmond city have all submitted applications the 11 special purpose schools represent schools that are dedicated to the education of special education students in particular those who are medically fragile and have difficulty attending school or completing course work because of their medical challenges. Four of the schools are alternative education schools that are dedicated to the

[02:15:21] education of students who are not successful in their home schools. The alternative schools who have submitted plans provide services for students who, for example, have behavior issues that impede learning, multiple suspensions, are behind in their attainment of graduation credits, and many times are students who have interrupted education. Some of the schools have a high number of l students and others have older age students who have returned to school to earn a diploma

[02:15:52] the alternative accreditation plans are listed in your board documents as attachment a so just for a little bit of history here the submission of alternative accreditation plans were a component of the accreditation process prior to the most revision recent revisions to the standards of accreditation in 2017. However, after the 2017 SOA were implemented, the alternative accreditation plans needed to be aligned with the new requirements and the new accreditation model.

[02:16:27] In January of 2020, the board asked that the department outline new guidelines for alternative accreditation plans and a working committee worked on those at the board's directive. november of 21 videoe staff discussed the new guidelines with the board to ensure that the guidelines met your expectations last year in april of 2022 the board approved the first alternative accreditation plans that aligned to the new guidelines the process for the submission

[02:17:02] approval and implementation of the plans as well as the flexibilities allowed to schools is provided as attachment b to your board item a very high level summary of the guidelines that are detailed in attachment b is that the framework of the state's accreditation model is kept intact but certain flexibilities are allowed within that framework for instance yesterday we talked about the improvement benchmarks that are in our state accreditation model in order to earn a particular

[02:17:35] level we also discussed that using those improvement benchmarks that benchmark reigns also required that schools met a certain level of improvement to demonstrate sufficient improvement and normally for instance with the achievement indicators that is ten percent so in for instance in these alternative accreditation plans that ten percent that improvement still exists but instead of a 10 improvement perhaps a school modified that to be a 5 improvement instead so

[02:18:15] the the framework exists but there are flexibilities in addition a school can add an indicator that specifically highlights the school's success and demonstrates that the school is raising student achievement and preparing students for post-secondary life the board is being asked to accept these alternative accreditation plans for first review final review and approval of these plans will be requested at the april business meeting and while there still may be some adjustments to these plans as they are prepared for your final review the structure of the plans

[02:18:55] themselves will remain the same the school divisions have also been informed that their presence may be requested at the final review should you have any specific questions for them Thank you very much, Ms. Sipka. Any questions by board members at this time?

[02:19:13] I think the presentation was so complete. Grace, no questions. Thank you very much. You're welcome. So the board will accept that for first review. Okay, item E, you'd like to go ahead?

[02:19:32] All right. Let me make sure I'm on the right one. Okay. So this next presentation is the first review of a proposal to adopt special provisions to suspend the use of the chronic absenteeism indicator for the determination of accreditation status in accreditation year 23-24, which is based on this school year's data 22-23.

[02:20:02] The board does have the authority to adopt special provisions related to the measurement and use of a school quality indicator, and the department is requesting the board suspend the use of the chronic absenteeism indicator for the determination of accreditation status in accreditation year 23-24 which again is based on this school year's data and essentially

[02:20:34] what that means is that if a school earns a level three in chronic absenteeism only instead of having the status of accredited with conditions the school would be given a status of accredited so we would still be reporting out the level we would still be reporting out the rate

[02:21:00] but it would not be used in the final determination of the school's accreditation status as you are all aware the chronic absenteeism is one of the nine indicators in virginia's school accreditation model and as a reminder chronically absent students are defined as those who miss 10 or more of their enrolled days this is excused and unexcused absences and in a typical 180

[02:21:38] school day year a chronically absent student would be absent for 18 or more days the chronic absenteeism indicator is a measure of the percent of students in a school that are chronically absent so for instance if you had a school with 180 school days you had 100 students at the school from day one to day 180, and 20 of those students were absent for more than 18 days, for 18 or more

[02:22:11] days, then that school's chronic absenteeism rate would be 20%. The school division leaders throughout this year have been reporting concern about increased absences despite the programs and procedures put into place to address chronic absenteeism. During the 22-23 school year, absences were exacerbated by contagious illnesses that were endemic during the same time period.

[02:22:44] That was COVID-19, RSV, and the flu. And anecdotal accounts also suggest student mental health plays a role in attendance post-pandemic as well as more cautious decision-making by parents when deciding whether to send a school with any symptoms of illness to school. In terms of the data, the chronic absenteeism data that we collect, the end-of-year student record collection

[02:23:19] is used to determine chronic absenteeism rates. Preliminary end-of-year chronic absenteeism data will be available at the beginning of august 2023 an analysis of videoe's spring src chronic absenteeism data which is data that's collected through march 31st would be completed by may 3rd since we do not have available at this time to help the board make a decision videoe staff

[02:23:59] collaborated with the virginia association of school superintendents vast to conduct an informal survey of school divisions to gauge the number of schools that have a chronic absenteeism rate over 25 percent as of february 28th rates over 25 percent are below the state benchmarks for level one and a level two so a level one is a rate that's less than or equal to 15 and a level two

[02:24:30] is a a rate that's greater than 15 but less than or equal to 25 so the results of the vast survey are on the screen the vast did collect estimations from school divisions again on the number of schools through February 28th that had a chronic absenteeism rate greater than 25 percent. So they were asked how many schools are in your division and how many schools had a chronic absenteeism rate greater than 25 percent. There were 85 divisions that responded to the survey

[02:25:09] representing all of the superintendent's regions and this survey represented 1,035 schools. of those schools 25.3 percent had a chronic absenteeism rate over 25 percent and just to give you a comparison in the two years prior to the pandemic approximately two to four percent of schools had that level of chronic absenteeism there is a an image of the region so you can see

[02:25:44] where the regions are in the state and then there's also a graph that shows the percent of schools with chronic absenteeism rates greater than 25 percent by region you can see that it does vary quite a bit region one which had 50 schools that responded to the survey there were only two out of those 50 schools that had chronic absenteeism rates greater than 25 percent you can compare that

[02:26:17] you can see that's a very vast difference from region eight they had um 19 out of 41 schools with a chronic absenteeism rate and then you can see the percentages for the other regions to just have a quick look back on chronic absenteeism for this current accreditation year in april of 22 the board adopted special provisions to suspend the use of the chronic

[02:26:52] absenteeism indicator for accreditation year 22 23 when there was a similar concern expressed by school divisions again if for this current year if a school earned a level three in chronic absenteeism only, the school was given a status of accredited, and for transparency, that performance level and the chronic absenteeism rate were still reported. And then in November 22, the board again adopted special provisions to exclude the 21-22 school year data from being used in subsequent

[02:27:30] accreditation year calculations. What that results in is for this current year, if the board takes no for their action. The performance levels will be based only on this year's data. So it would be based on the current year rate only. Because of the continued number of absences the school division leaders are reporting, the board is now being asked to consider the adoption of special provisions to suspend the chronic absenteeism indicator from the determination of school

[02:28:07] accreditation status for 2324 and in doing so the performance level and the chronic absenteeism rate will still be assigned to and reported for schools based on the current year's performance only and the board is being asked to accept this proposal for first review and it's currently scheduled to be brought before the board for final review at the april business meeting any thank you any questions we just still stress go ahead mr henson i'm sorry i didn't see you i just am struggling

[02:28:46] with this i believe that we're also sending a wrong message to our school systems in doing this and i understand the data and the review but this is just i think a very um mixed message that we're sending across the commonwealth and i just um i'm having a hard time being able to come to grips on and how I can support this.

[02:29:11] So I just, I don't know what we're hearing from the field. If this is, you know, from totally an accreditation and a process versus implications for students around the Commonwealth and what is being done at the local level to ensure that we're getting back to normal, that we're having students in their seats.

[02:29:32] It's the most important thing that we can do is to have students in school, class time, face time. And I feel like we're sending a signal that that's not important know we're kicking the can down the road so i just like whatever feedback we might have along those lines in the uh write-up of the board item there the the last section i believe um in that cover page went through the the professional learning opportunities that the office of school quality and the office of student services has been doing with the school divisions and it has been quite

[02:30:08] extensive, the work that they have been doing, and there has been a great deal of participation as well in what they're offering. I have asked them to be present at the meeting if you had any questions about that.

[02:30:27] But there, again, there has been quite a bit of involvement by school leaders in this process of trying to engage students and the feedback we've been getting is regardless of all of the the supports they're putting into place they're still having issues and i would echo mr hanson's comments here honestly it's i'm happy to hear them that you know we can't teach unless

[02:31:02] they're in school when they are you know i remember when we first put this into the current accreditation system, the pushback we got from the field, which was we can't possibly control who's coming to school. And yet, I think the data would bear out that after we put it in, in certain places in the Commonwealth, they were able to drop the chronic absenteeism rate substantially with fairly minor interventions. We are not back to that sort of normalized,

[02:31:34] those normalized years yet. But my point is that it is, you know, we always hear from the locals that we know our schools and we know our kids and let us do what we need to do. So rather than have the state impose how this has to be done, the flexibility I believe we gave the local divisions allows them to, you know, do what needs to be done in order to get kids in seats. I mean, the idea that 25% of the kids are missing 10% or more of the school year is staggering. You know,

[02:32:09] we understand that we lost a lot during the virtual years of the pandemic. And to now say that we, that is okay. It seems to me, again, you know, we talked yesterday about masking problems, this massive problem. And I hope the board, I mean, rarely lobby for something, but,

[02:32:28] You know, I understand, again, how much pushback, you know, I was up at the School Boards Association last week, and, you know, it is clear they don't want this responsibility, and I get that because it is not clear that enough resources flow to the locals to undertake this too.

[02:32:50] but the responsibility has got to be somewhere. And it may be, we need to look for more state funding to put in place programs to bring kids back to school, or it may be, you know, but it's clear the responsibility has got to be there at some point in the system. And again, as we talked about yesterday, the accreditation system being used as a systemic incentive, this to me is exactly what we were talking about. You know, we can't teach them unless they're there. And this is the incentive for the locals to bring him in yeah thank you i would even just respectfully asked

[02:33:27] if there is some data that we can see if there's a direct correlation to that 25 percent with of sol learning lost for the student populations that are most vulnerable as well because i imagine it's very much almost a very direct correlation and so i you know as we're trying figure out how we can stem the learning loss fix catch up i would like to understand that data as well especially before final review next month and i would also like to echo my comments from

[02:34:03] yesterday of asking from the department a summary of all of the covid and asset dollars that have been provided from the federal government to the commonwealth to every district in the commonwealth how those monies have been spent so that we can understand what school districts have been spending this unprecedented amount of money flowing into the system also to have an understanding of what is left to be spent and what the plans are around the commonwealth

[02:34:39] at the district level as well as the state level so as we're trying to address challenges as this we have a clear understanding of where the priorities of the districts and the state are and um using these once in a lifetime purposes to try to fix a once in a lifetime of challenge that we've been facing and so i would like to have both of those data points before the april meeting i think just really briefly i think mr

hanson you you went right to the place i was going at least in terms of really trying to understand the relationship between how

[02:35:13] well children are doing these groups when you look at rates like we just saw i my heart sank deep to know that there are places where over 46% of schools are struggling with chronic absenteeism. Our children are hurting. There is something that we have to wrap our minds around, understanding that's keeping children from school. And it's not just a school issue. I think

[02:35:46] even as we undertake these efforts and reach out to support our district's community, the community plays a role also in schools building partnerships with community. They can't do it by themselves. I know they can't, but I sit on this board as a person who works in community in partnership with our district because we know how important it is to have children there. And I just agree that we cannot, as painful as it feels, to have to have this considered as a part of accreditation

[02:36:25] taking it away. It's just deeply worrisome. President, Ms. Davis-Vault, or Dr. Davis-Vault, excuse me, first. President Gecker, if I could add some on-the-ground perspective to help with the understanding of these impoverished communities around, say, I have several points.

[02:36:51] Number one is that the attendance of the chronic absenteeism is a good point to measure. a good point to pay attention to because it's a symptom of a larger community and there are school divisions that have been very successful in increasing the the attendance rates for their students i can name smith county dr dennis carters may have been a fantastic job of bringing in their students but throughout this pandemic and after the pandemic we need to look at what our students lives are like and those numbers sadly are telling us what the students are going through

[02:37:28] especially when you look at impoverished communities where the students not are not coming from middle-income homes they're coming from homes that are sad to say priorities in the family are less than what you would expect other families to have their student securities there's drug abuse there's neglect there's there's a total lack of supervision in some of these areas or you have grandparents and single mothers raising children doing the best that they can possibly do When I hear chronic absenteeism numbers, you have to dig a little bit deeper to think and understand.

[02:38:05] And Dr. Mann, you said this so well. There's more at stake here in the community, in the locality for these children. Elementary-age children, pre-K, K-12345, they typically cannot get themselves up and out the door to get on that school bus.

[02:38:21] That is the responsibility of a parent. And a lot of times, that doesn't exist in these communities. A lot of times, it's an older student who's doing the best that they can do to get out the door. So you can't really measure the success of the school based on whether an elementary child has an alarm clock, can tell the time, or get to school, or have breakfast, or get themselves dressed.

[02:38:44] Now, you possibly could extend that to a middle school student or a high school student. But it's very difficult in trying times on a good day to get to school. with our children in these communities they do not go to the doctor when they need to they rely on the school nurse to make somewhat some recommendations to the family to take this child to a doctor and many times the family cannot get the child to a doctor and in the state of virginia on these communities that border other states that have educational neglect laws we don't have those

[02:39:20] so when our students disappear and they go to another state and become truant and then all of a sudden they come back to us a couple months later because truancy caught up with them in the other state it's very difficult for us to see where these children are how much school they've missed what can we do to get to them and then on top of that another point is mental health and governor gunkin did you point out some things that we needed to be aware of but public education is really struggling with mental health for the students and their families in order to get these children to the school as well as providing for special education children who are also trying to

[02:39:59] get themselves up and raise themselves up to get on the bus so it's a symptom of a greater issue that's at stake here it's not just um numbers and money and financial awareness it's some of that too but from my perspective in the classroom do i want that children and that child do i want that child in that seat to learn absolutely but sometimes it takes just a little bit more thought more planning more time to get that child there i've seen divisions and i've seen principals and i've seen teachers go that extra mile to get those children into the classroom

[02:40:36] but they can't learn because of the traumatic situations that they're living under is so severe so as we take a look at this chronic absenteeism let's let's think about the child sitting in the seat doing the best they can without the bath without the food without the support from home without the parental guidance without the priorities that most of us in the middle income home have let's think about that because we are the most stable eight hours of these children's days that we could possibly get so let's try to remove those barriers thank you

[02:41:12] thank you uh dr davis well dr siebert um yeah dr davis very very well spoken for the again boots on the ground perspective i'd like to take us back to the presentation we had in the fall from external experts about accreditation accountability systems they told us at that point in time that most states do not use chronic absenteeism as an accountability score measure they absolutely measure it absolutely report it post it significantly because it's hugely important and the reason they shared was is because it is a measure that is not exclusively in the school's control. Mr. Hanson, you made a very good point about the correlation between chronic

[02:41:48] assiduities and achievement. That's the other reason why, because it really is a double jeopardy. The children who are not in class are not achieving, and so the achievement measure is already holding schools accountable for that piece. Again, report it because it's a problem, transparently put it there. We have divisions in each of our regions. There's a superintendent designated to work with a colleague in the judges group, and so these conversations are ongoing all the time but even right now post pandemic um and i want to speak on behalf of juvenile court judges when i have one best ever seated next to me and we'll hear from her a moment

[02:42:26] but they're lacking tools also the tools that the tools in virginia exist right now for juvenile court judges are like to find the parent well these families don't have any resources in the first place incarcerate the parent well if it's a single parent home then that child now goes into foster care these so we we this is a major issue absolutely absolutely needs to continue to be tracked prominently recorded um and announced but right it is a lot of these issues are outside school's control um making part of the accreditation system dings the schools for things that are outside their control when they're already going to take the hit on student achievement for these

[02:43:02] children who are not in the seats um the flip side is is schools right now are working very very hard to close achievement gaps and make up ground and and and great progress is being made there so so i fast forward to the fall i would like to see schools that really did make grounds with student achievement get accredited because they made student achievement not get a credit because they made student achievement but then lose it because oh by the way some of these factors outside of their control prevented them from from earning it so it is very complex there's no doubt We've got to have children in school, but I think even our court system needs better tools to help make that happen.

[02:43:40] Ms. Halton, I guess you are the aforementioned judge. So the role of the courts and how the courts can be more helpful, that's a separate conversation, but it is challenging, no doubt about it, challenging for families.

[02:43:57] especially you know we are seeing continue there absolutely are continuing impact of the pandemic parents getting child care parents addressing health issues children still having health issues and as you pointed out not just the covet but other health issues this year and yet i totally get mr hansen's point and some of it is almost um it's it's the symbolic value and we just got got to have a culture shift. You know, this pandemic has created a culture shift that's

[02:44:31] tolerating people not going to school and in a huge way across the way, way too many parts of the Commonwealth. And I think the best argument for taking chronic absenteeism out is Alan's point about it simply tracks the other measures that are already in the accountability system. But But the timing of taking it out now when we're trying to deliver a message to help our school divisions implement, incite, encourage a culture shift of we've got to get back to kids have got to go to school.

[02:45:07] And we've all got, it's got to be an all hands on deck across communities to get kids back into school. That I just think the timing of, you know, we've made exceptions during the heart of pandemic. And now we are at a point where we're managing and learning to live with this thing.

[02:45:26] I just, even if we ultimately decide to take it out as part of the phase one accountability, let's get back to letting this accountability system have a shot at working. You know, we've only put this system in place in 1819, and now we've had the pandemic pulling the rug out from under it for two or three years. Let's see what happens if we actually work this system for a little while as we're contemplating changes to it so i i feel the pain of the school divisions but i um and all of that's by way of a comment rather than a question i guess

[02:46:03] you know i'll just direct it to the extent the school divisions and we did hear from mr braven earlier on this and i i feel the pain but if you all can come back and help us understand how are we going to get better on this without keeping our eye on the ball and how are we going to help the general public understand so this is an invitation to you all to continue to work with the stakeholders and come back and tell us next month how we're going to how we're going to improve on this measure if we don't stay focused on it mr president yes sir the ultimate responsibility

[02:46:42] for children to be in school is to parents is their job to get them up every morning to get get them to school. Some parents are choosing not to send their kids to school because you have those peaks of flus. A lot of kids are going home. Some parents are saying, I'm going to keep my child home until the number of sick kids go down. Some kids are working remotely and traveling. Some parents are working remotely, traveling with their kids across the country. They're using online coursework. The schools and the staff is working very hard to educate the kids while they

[02:47:18] have them in school. This will be one less thing that the school divisions have to fight for as far as being penalized. When that kid comes in school, the teachers teach. They shouldn't be penalized because a parent chooses at some point not to send their child to school because they have other obligations. So I support this being removed wholeheartedly because parents do their job, teachers do their jobs. So as we're living in a different world, as they say, it will never go

[02:47:56] back to what it was before. Constantly move forward. You adapt. That's why we have way more online training, online courses that people can do remotely. So as far as taking something away from the schools, as far as we're here, we're on a higher level, looking down. We have these ideas.

[02:48:14] It's just an idea. The local school divisions, they know what works when they teach their kids. And I will support the opportunity to, and granted, students, well, the schools are still going to try to get the kids in school. They're going to make the phone calls when a kid isn't there.

[02:48:30] is the child okay and if the child doesn't come for x number of days they're going to send someone out to do a home visit check them but i support the um the concept of removing this as a penalty mr rotherham did you have a comment i think yeah i i have a couple of colleagues more more of a comment the punch line is i have concerns um about this uh you know the early days of the pandemic we were working with schools and you would find among teachers there'd be wildly different levels of engagement with students, students logging on, students doing their work. And some schools went and asked the teachers who were getting good results, "Hey, what are you doing? Why is this

[02:49:08] happening?" And some schools did not. And we're just like, "Well, it's just one of those things." And I think we can all agree one of those things is better practice. And so what Ms. Davis-Vaught said resonated with me. Some divisions are having more success than others, and I think we do need to figure out like what's working and and all of that and and so fundamentally this points up i think our accountability accreditation problem because like we are still in a strange place the pandemic even though we're coming out of it we don't want to zig and zag too much on the same token this is a serious indicator this is important um so i guess uh i have concerns

[02:49:46] and i worry and and and i haven't heard it here today i think this has been a great discussion but around the commonwealth you hear people who say like much of the stuff we heard school divisions need to step up they do all this and then you do still hear people talk about this a little bit like it's the weather and what can you what can you do it's going to happen and i think that that that is troubling and we need to make sure we don't there are things that schools can do here we're seeing it we need to learn about and encourage it i think mr hansen's point on you know the resources that we have which really are i'm hoping the pandemic's a once-in-a-lifetime thing, but those resources are certainly that slug of money. I think we need to look at all

[02:50:23] that. So, like many of my colleagues, I do have concerns about where this potentially takes us. I think this is first review. I would like to ask staff next time. I think we had enough or had some data when we put this measure in about change in chronic absenteeism across the Commonwealth from before we put it in to after we put it in. And again, that would be helpful for us, I think, so that we could understand, you know, people have made the point, you know, it's unfair because schools can't control it. You know, I'd like to know if schools were able,

[02:50:58] in fact, to impact this measure after we put it in, and the data would demonstrate that. And second, just as a general point, you know, we sort of seem to take as an article of faith that the

achievement measure is actually a good measure of how well schools are teaching, When in fact, it correlates so highly to the demographics that it's unclear that it is really a measure of how well schools are teaching.

[02:51:22] And I'm not sure, which is not to say our schools aren't teaching well, but it is to point out that, you know, there too, it's a measure that's out of the control in some respects of what the schools are doing because they don't control their demographics. And, you know, if you look at the correlation data, it's so strong in terms of correlating socioeconomics to achievement that it's hard to ignore.

[02:51:48] You know, we have talked about, and I still hope we're moving toward a system that actually measures the value added, in a sense, of schools, the growth measures we've talked about for students. You know, the current Secretary of Education is in a unique position, actually, given her career to assist this board in that regard that is moving toward, you know, seeing how well schools are really doing. You know, we've talked before about, you know, kids from parents on the higher socioeconomic spectrum. Do we need to worry about them? Sure. But do we need to worry about them as much? Probably not, because they're going to get what they need by virtue of who their parents are.

[02:52:26] We still need to be concerned about the lower socioeconomics because they're not going to get necessarily what they need. And if what we claim is true, which is that we are interested in outcomes, then we really do have to focus on what creates the issues that, you know, inhibit outcomes.

[02:52:42] You know, part of that may be attendance, part of it's the socioeconomics, you know, but we need to focus more seriously on this. But I would not take bottom line as an article of faith that the achievement scores really measure value added in the way that they've been used. But we're not saying, and this comes up, and I do need, like, we're not saying as a board that we somehow think demographics are destiny. I think we can disagree on that either.

[02:53:05] Well, we just said the correlation is so high. There are schools that beat the odds every day in this Commonwealth and around the country. And I get, I just, this comes up again and again, I get very uncomfortable when we start down, well, it's demographics. That, that, that is flirting close to this. Well, what can, what can we do? What can we expect? And that, you know, the demographic challenges are real, but we can expect every kid in this Commonwealth, their parents have the right to expect that we're expecting success, and I think we should be expecting success. Absolutely, and we have the obligation to provide the resources necessary to

[02:53:39] facilitate that success. I believe every child or every demographically can succeed, but again, it is worth looking at what resources we put in to determine are we doing what we need to be doing as a commonwealth to cause those, to allow those children to succeed in the way that they should well and i continue to believe that sometimes we think about education in such an insular way and i i just have to go back to community and i think the thing that dr davis bought mentioned is so important and i absolutely agree that children are the responsibility of

[02:54:13] parents um yet you know when families encounter issues that destabilize their lives children are affected by that. The eviction rate in our community increased by 372% this year. And I'm here to tell you, that's going to have some effects on children being in schools. When parents are not able to address housing, food needs, children are affected. And I think

[02:54:52] schools in partnership with community is critical to get at this because the challenges that schools are facing, they can't be shouldered by schools alone. And sometimes schools are very, it's very difficult to get in there and lock arms with schools and support schools. And I say that as someone who's seen that challenge from other agencies wanting to come in, but it's difficult.

[02:55:21] Schools have a lot to manage in the course of educating children, but if we're going to get past what has happened as a result of the outcome of the pandemic and really just where we are at this state, we've got to be working.

[02:55:38] We've got to be lifting up where partnerships, community, and schools is an excellent example. I know it's not everywhere, but there are partners that can join together with schools to help support families where there is struggle and economic challenge. And that's real. And we're not going to help more children succeed if we're not willing to wrap our minds around how we do that better. I think that is absolutely correct. I disagree with almost nothing you said, Dr. Mann, except with a big asterisk. This is the Board of Education. I understand. And so like, I would like, there's lots of things I would like to see happen, but this is a lever we control, which is

[02:56:18] what are we expecting? What is the level of our expectations? And I know you don't intend it that way, but when, not you, Dr. May, but with respect, President Gecker, when people hear the correlation on demographics, it's so high and so forth, it does lead to a culture of, oh, what can we do and so forth, rather than a culture of we've got to power through this. And I mean, there's like ample literature, there's chapter and verse on this, and we just want to make sure that we're being very specific about a really high level of expectations, as well as a high level of support, and then we can talk about these other things that we hope happen, but are out of our specific purview. Well, they're out of our purview, but I think if I'm going to take opposition to

[02:56:57] something, you know, on the basis of feeling like not having it included is sending a statement that speaks directly to the point that you made, I also want to be able to talk about why I have that point of view, right? And I think that a piece of that really does demand that we find more ways to get at the kinds of issues that Dr. Davis-Vaught articulated that really speak to, you know, this is not just people saying, I don't want my kids going to school. This is not, this is not that exclusively. I think we're actually in vigorous agreement. I think

[02:57:36] what happens though is this too often becomes an or conversation. We can have accountability or resources. We can have high expectations or, and this is an and conversation. We should do both of these. And again, some of this stuff's out of our purview. Some of it, again, to Mr. Hansen's point, we're sort of an unprecedented situation. But it's an and conversation. It's talking about doing both of these things. And they do, and I think you can just see the dialogue, and not just the Commonwealth, but nationally, these things get pitted against each other, too often high expectations and a high level of support. Those things, they should go hand in glove.

[02:58:12] Andy, I would even, it's not just an and, but it's also, I think, a comma, I think, to the spending question it's also just not about the dollars it's how the dollars are spent and so it's um so i think that's got to be an important ingredient and i really am looking forward to the robust conversation we're going to have about our accountability reform and you know how this does or doesn't you know fit into what are the true indicators and things that we need i know there's other pieces but i'm just going to go back to where i started that i don't like sending this

[02:58:45] message at this time, even as an employer and, you know, having a family and others working remotely and being used to maybe going to work three days a week, or we just have a cultural issue, I think, as Ms. Holton said, that we've got to focus on right now. And this is a unique period in time where we're coming out of this. And so I'm just going back to where I started from that I'm just not, I'm going to vote no on this, even for first review and happy to be a minority vote on that, but that's where I am. Let me, thank you. Let me just, but I don't want to

[02:59:20] debate this, Mr. Rotherham, but I disagree with your conclusion that noticing the correlation leads people to throw up their hands and say, what can we do about this? I think it's just the opposite. I think it leads people to investigate what the underlying causes are. And this board, you know, through its work on the comprehensive plan and the standards of quality that we prescribed, understood the importance of teachers to change that and building leadership.

[02:59:44] You know, one of the things I was happiest about with the new superintendent coming in is Tennessee is a place that has recognized the importance of building leadership and principles and training of principles. And I'm hopeful that we move as a Commonwealth toward that kind of focus on who's in front of our kids, what experience levels in front of our kids and who's running the buildings.

[03:00:07] Because both of those things, you know, teachers first and building leadership second, have been shown to have the highest impact on outcome. And it is not I don't think we can do anything about it. It's not destiny. What it is, is an opportunity to learn. You know, I think you and I may have talked yesterday about Karen Chenoweth's book. You know, it's you look at those places that have succeeded and why have they succeeded? And if you, you know, read her book, what it says is because the principals were better. They did a better job putting building leadership in, which caused the teachers to be better at what they were doing, you know, and that improved those outcomes. That, to me, says that there's a model we can

[03:00:45] follow, not that it's hopeless and, you know, demographics are destiny. In any event, we are happy to accept this item on first review. I look forward to next month's conversation on it, but yeah, it is clear that it's, you know, most in the minds of the board, what should the accreditation system look like? What should we incentivize? How is it going to work? How are we going to improve outcomes and you know i find the discussion to be very healthy in that regard that you know we have different viewpoints we have different work experiences life experiences and you know i have

[03:01:22] every confidence that the board will come up with and a system that accomplishes the goals that we want for the benefit of our children so with that having been said miss sepa this seems to be your day uh item f all right um this item is the first review of the request to approve the proposed

[03:01:57] growth mel the proposed growth methodology uh beginning with the 2022 2023 school year so growth for students who failed the state assessments on the grades four through eight math and reading state assessments was included in the state accountability system for the first time in accountability year 2018-19 and that was based on the 2017-18 data and

[03:02:34] was included because of the revisions to the standards of accreditation. Growth is a component of the combined rates in all of the academic achievement indicators for math and reading.

[03:02:50] So it's used in academic achievement math, academic achievement English, achievement gap math, and achievement gap English. Initially, when growth was included in the combined rate, growth

was demonstrated by the use of a year-to-year comparison of state assessment results.

[03:03:15] So it was comparing the previous spring test results to the current year spring test results to determine whether a student demonstrated growth. Legislation in the 21 General Assembly amended the standards of quality to include the administration of growth assessments for grades 3 through 8, reading and math, with at least one beginning of year, one mid-year, and one end-of-year assessment.

[03:03:52] Full implementation of the growth assessments occurred over a two-year period, so during the 21-22 school year, only a beginning-of-year fall growth assessment was given, and during During the 22-23 school year this year, there was a fall growth assessment and a mid-year growth assessment, which was given in the wintertime.

[03:04:14] So due to the addition of the growth assessments in Standard 3 in 2021, the board approved a new methodology to determine growth so that the methodology included both a year-to-year comparison of standards of learning results as well as a comparison of fall growth assessment results to the current spring SOL test results.

[03:04:41] So specifically for that 21-22 school year, growth was determined by first comparing the spring 22 test results to the spring 21 test results. And if that did not show growth, then the spring 22 results were compared to the fall 21 growth assessment results to determine whether there was growth.

[03:05:05] And I know that Shelly said this yesterday, but just so we're clear, students who show growth, it has to be students who failed the current year's assessment and also failed the previous year's assessment in order to show growth.

[03:05:24] So it's just failing students, the lower level of those ranges. So here is somewhat of an explanation of growth in that 21-22 school year.

[03:05:39] So the reason we could use the spring 21 or the fall 21 test results is that initial comparative data was because in that first year of implementation, the fall 21 growth assessments measured the previous year's content.

[03:05:57] And that was the same content that was measured by the spring 21 SOL test. So if you look at that table, this is an example of a grade five student in the 2020-21 school year. So in the spring of 21, that grade five student took a grade five reading SOL test.

[03:06:19] And the content of that assessment was grade five reading. forward to fall of 21 when that student is in grade six and that student took the grade six reading fall growth assessment. During that fall 21 fall growth assessment administration that growth assessment actually measured grade five content. So you can see the spring 21 test

[03:06:52] and the fall 21 test both measured grade five content. So when we did the comparison to spring of 22, it was grade five to grade six content. And it was the same regardless of what comparison we used. So the exception to this was for grade three students. So students take an end of year SOL test in reading and math for the first time in grade three. So there was only one comparison

[03:07:28] that was available to determine growth. So the fall growth assessment, which measured grade three content, was compared to the spring SOL test, which also measured grade three content to determine whether a student measured growth. So that was the exception. So there were changes to the

growth assessments in the 22-23 school year so based on direction provided by previous virginia department

[03:08:01] of education leadership the content level of the growth assessments changed this school year so unlike the fall 21 growth assessments that focused on content from the students previous grade level the 22-23 school year fall and winter growth assessments focused primarily on content from the student's current grade level so because the growth assessments no longer focus on the previous year's content the methodology approved by the board in july 21 is no longer applicable does that make

[03:08:39] sense so far okay so the department is requesting that the board approve for grades four through eight the use of only a year-to-year comparison of state assessment results in the methodology to determine whether a student demonstrates growth and this will allow the student's performance on the previous year's content to be compared to the performance on the current year's content for grades four through eight and there is an example here where in spring of 22 a student

[03:09:14] was in grade three took the grade three reading or vap test on grade three reading content and in spring of 23 when that student was a fourth grader taking the grade four test that measured grade four content again there would need to be an exception for grade three so for grade three we would use the same methodology that was used previously so we would compare

[03:09:52] the fall growth assessment results to the current spring test results and you can see in the table how the comparison for grade three would be grade three reading content in fall of 23 compared to grade three reading content in spring of 2023. I do have one note under the table and that is that VAP students and grade three students who participate in VAP testing will not be included

[03:10:25] in accountability growth calculations under this proposal because they do not take growth assessments so the reasons for using only a year-to-year comparison there's there's a couple reasons first of all the administration of on grade level through your growth assessments occurred for the first time this year and we do not have any longitudinal data to guide decisions regarding how much through year growth a student would need to make on a particular test to

[03:11:02] demonstrate sufficient progress so at this this point we we do not have data also student growth is part of virginia's accountability plan or federal accountability plan and the growth measure methodology that we used in 21-22 doesn't meet federal guidelines so we were able to use it last year because there were some flexibilities that uscd had to allow us to do it because of

[03:11:34] cover covid but that methodology that we used last year cannot be used this year so we do need to submit an amendment with another methodology the methodology that uses only the year-to-year comparison was previously approved by uscd and we don't anticipate any issues getting that methodology approved for federal accountability should the board approve approve it for use for state accreditation and in addition we did communicate with uscd about the exception for the grade three students and at this point it appears they would support that exception

[03:12:14] and allow a comparison of fall growth assessment results to spring assessment results lastly students who participate in the vap assessment are included in our growth calculations and this population of students do not take fall or winter growth assessments so the determination of growth for these students must be based on year-to-year comparison and so approving only a year-to-year comparison for students who participate in sol testing would also parallel this methodology

[03:12:53] so the department is asking the board's approval to use only a year-to-year comparison of state assessment results which is the previous spring test results to the current spring test results for grades four through eight students within the growth determined methodology and a comparison of fall growth assessment results to current spring sol results for grade three students and this methodology would begin with this current school year that we are in right now 22-23 and continue

[03:13:25] until there is sufficient data to support a different methodology okay we are asking the board to accept this for first review and final review is anticipated at the april 20th business meeting. Thank you very much. Any questions? Ms. Hulton. Thank you, Ms. Sivka. My first question is the law that was passed that required us to do the fall and mid-year assessments. There's nothing

[03:14:05] in that law that requires us to use that fall assessment for our growth measures. In other words, we're required to do the assessment, but we're not required to use it for this accountability purpose right so we're not so your proposal is not in conflict with that statutory requirement does it make that statute requirement irrelevant in other words we are giving those fall assessments but we're not using them so is it um undermining the spirit of that law or not do you want to

[03:14:37] address that shelley i think the the spirit of the legislation was to provide more actionable information to parents and teachers in a more timely fashion so i mean you are correct that it has a different use when it's not used for accountability but i think the the real intent behind this was to provide more actionable information um for for parents and teachers

[03:15:10] well i was glad when that legislation passed because it finally gave us a basis for having a third grade growth measure for the benefit of the new council new board members for many years we said we were taking into account growth at all grades, but we weren't at third grade because we had no before picture to compare it to. So that legislation did give us a before picture for third grade, and this is allowing us to continue to keep that. The issue itself is sufficiently

[03:15:43] complex that I defer to your expertise. I would want to make sure that you've gathered input from expertise of our stakeholders so i would and i'm sure they'll come tell us if they've got a problem with it but i hope you all are affirmatively reaching out to the education stakeholder groups on this and will if they have concerns be ready to address them when we come back next month mr president we've just touched on a huge issue for the future assessment in the 585 group etc

[03:16:19] and that is currently we talk about student growth but but really we're not measuring student growth we are actually measuring progress of students who failed and every child in the commonwealth deserves to have their progress their growth measuring and reported to every parent every parent should be able to celebrate the progress the growth their individual child made every teacher should be able to celebrate the product the growth that individual students in their class made and that is not what our current assessment tools permit us to do now i think uh just great part what my colleagues just brought up about the original tentative legislation a lot of us helped that legislation worked hard on that legislation we're excited about that legislation but when it

[03:16:57] came to the department and this board it was well let's try to do it through the tools we already have and so that has led to great consternation because at the in the divisions now who are already doing growth measures and already getting called out for over testing now here comes the state test it gets laid on top of it so some schools decided to stop doing the actual better tools they had for the sake of this tool which we now know the longitudinal data is not there and the sales pitch of oh it's going to help you with

your growth is not even going to be the case either so we just spent a really commendable period of time talking about the importance of

[03:17:36] attendance and having children in school once we have children in school what's important is time teaching and learning. And so this current approach using this current tool requires that you basically shut down the school, use your lockdown browsers, have your proctors in the hallways, have your authorization proceeds, your test security agreements in place, and you lose a day of instruction in the fall, you lose a day of instruction in the winter, and now it's not going to generate the benefits that were purported. So what I would like to ask for final review is that staff in fact look at the original legislation and and and the way i understand it and what we

[03:18:14] kind of thought going into it as we celebrate its passage was that um there would be individual measures of student growth to bear so perhaps in the coming year um we can use the school test identifier for divisions that have growth measures be it i-ready or map or whatever proven tool they have to report individual student growth using a student test identifier and and divisions who didn't have those tools which we've always been worried about the divisions who didn't have them then this pearson tool could be available to them because it exists and it is there but the reporting from this tool is inferior to what we were getting for a decade before

[03:18:51] um the the loss of instructional time when you can give them these other assessments in 45 minutes and for these tests um by the time you set it up set up take it down move the kids the testing zone you lose an entire day of instruction that juice is not worth the squeeze and now even the idea that it was going to help with with accreditation is not not being realized so yes this past year we've already done the fall and the winter assessment that time is lost i would hate for that structural time to be lost in 23 24 um when i don't think that was the intended original legislation i think there's other ways that we can do this thank you any other

[03:19:29] comments or questions yes i understand this right i understand this right we're using different tests basically they're scaled the way that we can that this works and here comes dr loving writer who's forgotten more about this than i know so perfect so these growth assessments are based on sol test items so and they are on the same vertical scale as the sol test so that was how we were originally

[03:20:06] intending to to measure growth i do want to also acknowledge that the grade three test that we talked about we did field test items that measure grade 2 content so we are in in a place where we will be able to better provide information about grade 3 students we also need for you all to understand that these tests are computer adaptive and so this year for the first time we did change the adaptive algorithm so that we are able to pick up items one grade level above or one grade level

[03:20:40] below depending on the student's performance on the on-grade level items but i know dr c that doesn't adapt to the extent that that you know the other commercial tests does that help mr rotherham yeah i mean like there's two issues like i think i put a lot of weight on dr siebert's concerns then there's just the second like if you set those aside for a second just is it technically over the years we've had trouble just given the nature of our assessment system sometimes doing some of the things that we would want to do and but you're confident that this we're good uh another thing about these is they are about half length of an sol test so they are shorter

[03:21:16] assessments uh just to from uh miss loving rider sorry make you play um uh stand up sit down but is mr do uh agree with dr siebert's assessment that the administering of our sol version of the growth

test is a more cumbersome administration than something like i ready or map he's saying 45 minutes versus closing the school down for a day um i think because they the growth assessments

[03:21:50] are based on sol test items we do have to maintain the security so while we've tried to relax the requirements around the growth assessments a bit it is still true that we have to use a lockdown browser because they they're items that are also administered on the sol test so an attempt has been made but it is not the same as a non-secure commercially available assessment one of the conversations we had when we were adopting our growth measures initially was should we try to move to something like i-ready or or map that the divisions are already using and one of the questions that we discussed then was how many divisions were using it do we have a

[03:22:28] sense of how pervasive those measures are in the divisions already they were using it even though we weren't paying for it or mandating it um we did collect some information i think about 18 months ago that we can certainly get to you all it will not be certainly fresh but we gathered information about um you know which divisions we're using which tests um i i think the the difficulty in using multiple assessments to measure growth is how you determine how much growth is sufficient on each of those assessments you know where with the growth assessments or the sol test you know

[03:23:07] everyone is taking the same test so it's easier to determine how much growth is sufficient so again you know we talked a lot about allowing uh other assessments but the challenge is then you know how do you determine how much growth is sufficient for accountability thank you everybody else um well i just wanted to add to that too um using a commercial test such as iready or map one of the things that um i think that that house bill 585 committee really needs

[03:23:42] to think about is the alignment of those tests to our standards. Having been in the field and seeing those tests, they often, questions that students are getting do not align to our standards. And I have seen that firsthand. So that is something that as the committee is weighing, is looking at the alignment. The other issue that I could just foresee with some of these other third-party products is, as Shelley said, if we're using something

[03:24:18] in an accountability model, we have to make sure that what that measure has integrity. And that does involve some sort of test security around it. So now when a division is offering a map test, for instance, there may not be the same security measures that would have to exist if we were were using it for our accountability model um and then lastly in in terms of time um there are a lot of students that take a lot of time to

[03:24:52] to take the um the third party vendor tests so i don't know that there is a great difference in the amount of time uh for the administration but i i do know that right now as um as dr siebert said there there is concern about using the growth assessments now and you know what information we can glean from them and that is simply something that we're working on because it was the first time that they were administered so one more point if we are trying to have one accountability system

[03:25:30] federal and state we have to submit whatever test we use it is another thing okay i think that covers that item for first view and it ends sipka day at the board thank you for the lively discussion

[03:25:51] all right we're going to do a 10 minute break we'll be back at 11 15. first review of updates

[03:40:01] to the board approved courses good morning good morning president gecker vice president mann members of the board and welcome mr sturdifant so my name is dr brandon albon i am the director

of the office of stem and innovation but this morning i'm bringing an item to you on behalf of the Office of Humanities represented by Ms. Nogueras and the Office of STEM and Innovation.

[03:40:29] We are proud to share with you today for first review the proposed updates to the Board of Education approved courses to satisfy graduation requirements for the standard and advanced studies diplomas in Virginia public schools document. Now typically the board approved courses document includes a list of courses within STEM fields and humanities content areas which are approved by the Board of Education for the conferring of credits for high school graduation in Virginia. It includes

[03:41:04] information for students and parents to see the list of course options which may be available within their Virginia public school. It includes information for receiving school divisions within Virginia and other states and institutions of higher education about courses that students have completed including the school course for exchange of data SCED code and it includes information about SOL assessments that are associated with Virginia courses. So some of

[03:41:40] the updates to the August 2022 document include specifically the addition of AP pre-calculus as a mathematics course and AP seminar for English 10. The addition of these course options provides more rigorous alternatives for school divisions to make available to their students. For English 10, school divisions may offer AP seminar for English in addition or as an alternative to regular or

[03:42:15] honors courses. For AP pre-calculus, school divisions may offer this as an AP level course primer for students who may choose to move on to the AP calculus courses or even dual enrollment calculus course offerings. We have updated for accuracy the SCED codes used to identify courses in which students are currently enrolled. This document clarifies and updates language regarding state and federal testing and state graduation requirements. We have removed unnecessary or

[03:42:50] outdated content, and we have edited it for accuracy, readability, and formatting, which have improved the document. These updates are necessary to ensure that local school divisions have appropriate notation of course enrollments in the master schedule collection, and that appropriate credits are used to satisfy graduation requirements, as well as to clarify answers to common questions for the 2023-2024 school year onwards.

[03:43:27] Therefore, the Superintendent of Public Instruction recommends that the Board of Education approve the proposed updates to the Board of Education-approved courses to satisfy graduation requirements for the standard and advanced studies diplomas in Virginia public schools for first review.

[03:43:47] Are there any questions? Any questions? Mr. Hanson. Were there substantive changes other than just the editorial and formatting and sequencing? No, sir. There were editorial changes, but primarily we have added the two courses, the AP Seminar for English 10 and the AP Pre-Calculus course.

[03:44:08] Those are new courses that have been put out by College Board, and we are making them available for schools to offer to their students as part of their regular course offerings. Thank you. Yes, sir. Anybody else? No, thank you. The board is happy to take this for first review.

[03:44:26] item H. I guess you'll be back in a moment, Dr. Albon. Yes, sir. Okay. Item H, Dr. Johnson.

[03:44:47] Again, I can't see around the corner. Is Dr. Johnson here? No. Dr. Albon, you want to go ahead

[03:44:57] and do item I? Thank you. Certainly. Yes, sir. So Chairman Gecker, Vice President, man, and members of the board, I am pleased to present to you an update of where we stand with regards to the

[03:45:34] College Partnership Laboratory Schools in Virginia. So this presentation will essentially cover a little bit of information about information that is in the interactive map that is available to the public so that everyone in the public is able to dig in and find out more about the current applications that are going through the lab school application processes. We're going to speak a little bit about some of the applications and then we're going to speak about the pipeline, the process of how we are moving forward to shared previously with you on the laboratory schools

[03:46:13] on the college partnership laboratory schools web page we have developed an interactive map which allows for anyone in virginia to be able to find out about which institutes of higher education are currently applying for either a college partnership lab school planning grant or a college partnership lab school startup grant I will differentiate between those two shortly information on this map is available to anyone to be able to find out what is going on and this is advantageous for us

[03:46:48] because what it does do is it provides an opportunity to not only share with the public what might be going on close to them what opportunities might become available to students in their locality in the near future but what it also does is it provides a community a practice whereby people who are considering applying for a lab school in the future can take a look around and see what is currently going on in the space of these applications so as any user clicks on to that interactive map you will see an enormous amount of information about each application

[03:47:26] and we picked one to share with you today being norfolk state and that is essentially what you see before you you'll see information when you click on there about contact details of the applicants themselves who it is who's applying on behalf of the institution and we are also including information specifically about what that planning grant or lab school application is pursuing what kind of lab school are they pursuing who are their partners what kind of information is out there. This, if I were an institute of higher ed looking to possibly do a

[03:48:03] lab school, this gives me a good sense of what model I might be able to follow. So as I said, this is publicly available and anyone is able to go in there. I'll dig into more of some of the applications for you shortly. This map that you have is a breakdown of all of the applications together and pardon the smallness of it, but you can essentially see that we have, if you look in the top left corner, you'll see a key which has for you in blue that we've got pending lab school applications. There are currently two institutes of higher ed who jumped straight to submitting a

[03:48:41] lab school application. We do have some planning grant applicants who submitted their applications and they are already approved, and I'll explain to you what that means momentarily, they are approved to pursue the development of a lab school as a concept. And then we also do have some plan and grant applications that we have received, and that explains the last two. So you are able to take a look around at that map. The key thing with this map that is key to show you

[03:49:17] is by region it shows how many of the school divisions around the commonwealth already have lab schools or potential lab schools coming close to them so you can see in every single region across the commonwealth we have school divisions who are already partnering with some of the applicants and that information is there as well as on the interactive map we have a sub page on the website that deals with lab schools, and these are the frequently asked questions.

[03:49:56] An important thing to realize about the laboratory school program is this is a whole new way of looking at schools in Virginia. We have traditional schools, we have magnet schools at the local level, we

have governor schools, we have governor STEM academies, and there are other regional programs related to student services, special education, etc. A laboratory school is a whole new creation so we are receiving many questions about well what is a laboratory school what makes this different how do i get started on it we are receiving many questions and balancing between receiving the questions or pre-empting trying to paint a picture for the

[03:50:35] public about what a laboratory school is and how to get in the process of applying for one many of the questions you see on the screen are ones that are addressed there now if i may i would like to take just a brief minute to kind of share basically what the big idea of what a college partnership laboratory school is it is a school that is operated by an institute of higher education and it is a school where students will go to and they will attend there are currently three types of lab schools that are more or less in operation the first kind is some kind of either

[03:51:12] early college or career development lab school where the institute of higher ed is partnering with a school division or multiple school divisions to give students greater avenues or on-ramps into careers or into college opportunities. The second type are lab schools that are trying different instructional pedagogies. We have some lab schools that are working with a teacher preparation program. They are coming alongside a school division to say, we want to support you. You've got a different way of trying things and we would like to work with your school division or divisions with that. The third kind of lab school is where there is a

[03:51:51] partnership between a school specifically and a school division to be able to say this may not be working, that may not be working, we'd like to try with you some different ideas. Now the word that everyone keeps using is lab and you'll notice I pronounce it differently, laboratory. That is a scientific word and that is primarily because what we are asking these schools to do is to try something different we want to learn are there best practices that can be implemented across the commonwealth that are not currently being implemented are there ideas are there pedagogies are there approaches are there things that might inform board action are there things that might

[03:52:31] inform code and legislative action to maybe change the way that public schools operate in virginia so we provide a space for these schools to do things perhaps in a slightly different way to inform back to the greater loop of schools, what is it that a public school can do with public school students.

[03:52:55] So there will be a feedback loop from these laboratory schools where we will take information from them. This worked. This didn't work. Maybe let's try that. But the whole goal of it is to ensure that we are able to provide the very best opportunities for students in Virginia in their learning.

[03:53:12] an institute of higher education to be able to create a lab school, they do have the option to apply directly for a lab school grant in Virginia. However, there is possibly a better mode, and many of the applicants that I will share with you today have gone through the mode of applying for a planning grant. A planning grant is an opportunity for an institute of higher ed to say, we've got this idea. We've got these potential partners, school divisions, other institutes of higher ed and industry to be able to say, we've got this idea. We want to put it together. It's not

[03:53:51] crystallized. It's not formalized. And what we as the agency, as well as a review team that does consist of people outside of the agency do is we do take a look at these. And if they're on the right track, they may not have it perfect yet. But if they're on the right track and they're headed due north, then we'll be able to say, yes, we will give you one year to take these ideas, to work with us on technical assistance, to

formalize, to be able to put it together. And then at the end of that year, they then have the option to apply for a full lab school grant. Those

[03:54:24] that apply directly for the lab school grant, apart from not getting the grant funds, are very often having to play catch up and to go there directly. A lot of that is a summary of what you will see in the answers on the FAQ page for the lab schools. So the planning grant applications, these are institutes of higher ed who applied for a grant. It is $200,000 per, up to $200,000 per, per Institute of Higher Ed. And when I mentioned Institute of Higher Ed, that does include Virginia public colleges. It does include community colleges. It does include some higher

[03:55:03] Ed centers, and it does include some private colleges that do work with the TAG grant system. The list of all eligible institutes of higher ed is available on the website. So what I am able to do is to share with you just some ideas that are being floated by some of these institutes of higher ed as they're looking toward their planning grants. We have received 20 planning grants applications thus far, which as we shared with you previously is an average of about one per week that we have been able to work through, process, and give technical assistance in some cases

[03:55:42] and get these off the ground. Fifteen of these have been awarded. We have three that are pending. In other words, they're in the process of review. We have one that we've received. We haven't started reviewing yet. And one of those was declined. So for the planning grants of the $100 million that was legislated toward the College Partnership lab school five million dollars was set aside to be able to support these institutes of higher education to be able to apply for a planning grant currently and my glasses are hurting me 2.8

[03:56:20] million dollars have already been sent to those applicants that have received that have submitted a successful planning grant we have about another 790 000 that may go to potential applicants who are currently under review and that does mean that we do currently have a balance of about one million three hundred seventy five thousand dollars that is available the thing that's not being said there that i'll say out loud is that this funding is finite and once we have enough

[03:56:56] lab schools that have applied for the money then we are not able to continue awarding lab schools unless there is further legislative action on that so very briefly i will go through some of the planning grants applicants received one from the university of mary washington their focus is on computer and data science they are working with stafford county schools king george schools caroline spottsylvania fredericksburg and they have already received partnership from several

[03:57:30] industrial partners including amazon and dhl amongst others the next one is mountain gateway community college which has a focus on cyber security cloud community and it support the school divisions that they are working with are allegheny bath rockbridge water tart and the city of buna vista they already have partnerships with with certain other institutes of higher ed such as the virginia military institute washington lee university and radford university next is george mason university they are looking to develop an accelerated college pathways academy

[03:58:09] focused on instructional technology they are partnered with fairfax county public schools and some of their industrial partners already include booze allen genesis works amazon web service boeing and periton one of the old dominion grants that we have received is for the maritime for the maritime and coastal innovation collaboratory i have to say that slowly their focus is on stem and cte their big focus is to work on shipbuilding as well as and and you'll see by

[03:58:47] the industrial partners they've already partnered with virginia space grant newport new shipbuilding huntington ingles industries and they will be working primarily with newport news public schools for that lab school closer to home the virginia commonwealth university is looking to partner with code rva and to work with that existing program to turn it into a lab school but to combine it with their teacher residency program to inform greater pedagogical practice for those

[03:59:22] instructional teachers one that i'm particularly excited about is out at eastern shore community College, where the Aerospace Academy Lab School is looking on developing a lab school that will focus on STEM careers, specifically in the aerospace industry. Remember, we are speaking about NASA Wallops Island Flight Facility, and they are going to be working with Northampton County Schools, Acomac, and Acomac County Schools. Moving on to Germanna, they are looking to develop a future

[03:59:56] teachers program and they already have several k-12 partners being culpepper orange madison and rappahannock emory and henry college headed back down into region 7 are looking to develop a healthcare excellence academy laboratory school for 10th through 12th graders they will be working with students in smith with washington bristol linwood holton governor school students and they already have other partners of institutes of higher ed the university of virginia is looking

[04:00:32] to work with charlottesville city schools and they are looking to they're proposing a seventh and eighth grade stem and computer science lab school the university of lynchburg who might need to pause because i got two degrees from them they are looking to partner with lynchburg city schools and to work specifically in a school to focus on a change in the approach to literacy instruction and the science of reading which ties nicely to some state operations that we're working on the

[04:01:09] second old dominion lab school is to develop an international baccalaureate middle school partnership with chesapeake city public schools and there are three tracks for that students who go through that lab school may potentially work on a career track an ib track or a dual enrollment track virginia union university also down the road is looking to develop a promise academy lab school for sixth through 12th grade students focused on steam science technology engineering arts and mathematics they're looking to lead students into virginia union's dual enrollment

[04:01:48] program they're partnering with richmond city public schools sorry richmond public schools and they already have industrial partners in altria genworth bank of america capital one ibm and dominion energy norfolk state university is looking to develop a pre-k through second grade reading for steam lab school that's an interesting one many of the lab schools are focused at the secondary level. It is interesting to see the possibility of what can we do at the primary level.

[04:02:23] That is an interesting one for us. Back to the Central Virginia Community College, they're looking to develop a CTE pathway lab school for students from middle school all the way through 12th grade. They're going to have programs in the local school divisions being Amherst, Appomattox, Bedford, Campbell and Lynchburg City and their focus is as students head toward 11th and 12th grade those students who will be on campus at CVCC. The next one is Piedmont Virginia Community College and they are looking to develop a lab school that is focused on advanced manufacturing and IT as well

[04:03:02] as an accelerated education to employment path and they are partnered with Albemarle, Charlottesville city louisa fluvana green nelson and buckingham county schools we do have several planning grants in the pipeline and these are ones that are under review virginia state university is looking to develop a stem lab school and they are part they are partnered with petersburg chestfield prince george

and dinwiddie public schools and they have already received industrial support from amazon and dominion energy as well as lego which is going to be situated right on their doorstep

[04:03:42] tidewater community college is a very interesting one that we are reviewing because they are actually looking to develop the possibility of a lab school that focuses on pre-k and that will feed directly into students who will go to the school divisions there they are working with portsmouth city public school and they are also working with eastern virginia medical school moving along to hampton university they are developing a k5 lab school with focus on visual

[04:04:16] and performing arts which as a person who has worked in gifted education i've seen a lot of opportunities for students to be able to get differentiated services particularly in mathematics and english but they're looking to propose opportunities for students specifically in the performing arts they've got a very interesting program that includes technology into that And they are partnered with Hampton City Schools.

[04:04:47] Roanoke College is proposing a high school lab school with career pathways into education. In other words, it's one of the teacher preparation ones where we will have teacher prep students working with the students at the lab school trying different pedagogical approaches.

[04:05:05] And they're going to focus on communications and civic leadership. And they are focused with Salem City Schools, partnered with Salem City Schools. At this point, we do have one declined planning grant, and that is New College Institute.

[04:05:21] It does not mean that the door is necessarily closed to them, but at this time, the application was not able to move forward to the approved stage. These slides are essentially a table that summarizes everything I just said to you. It puts all of the information in one place.

[04:05:38] Some interesting things for you to do is to be able to line up and take a look at which grade levels are being supported. Some are high school, some are elementary school, some are middle school. You'll see every region across the Commonwealth has at least one potential lab school, if not more.

[04:05:55] And you'll see the school divisions that are being proposed, as well as the instructional foci in those. That is on all of these slides. So those are the applicants that have come through the planning grant phase.

[04:06:10] The next phase is to actually get to the point of being able to submit a lab school application. and this moves a little bit closer to the locus of the board of education and your control specifically this is when they get closer to your approval i'm going to share with you just some updates to what's going on there you will recall that at the february board of meeting we the board voted to approve some substantive and administrative improvements to the guidelines

[04:06:44] that surround lab school applications. One of which was that it eliminated the one-year barrier of time of a lab school submission to the launch of a lab school. What that did is it allows applicants to be able to start their lab school in a much faster turnaround from the time of approval, which means that the following three needed to follow suit. We eliminated the nine-month barrier for an applicant to contract with the board to 90 days within the approval of a lab school there was the elimination of a six-month barrier prior to the opening of a local school board to apply

[04:07:24] for initial waivers one of the things about lab school is we're encouraging lab schools to try different things there might be things they will come back and they will specifically ask the board these are things that we would like to try differently there will be limitations based on code and based on the standards of quality but there are some things that will be under your purview to approve and we've also reduced the six-month barrier for the applicant to have all school leadership in place down to two months prior to the opening of school so all of those

[04:07:56] things tied together so the next step the process of how a lab school applicant becomes a lab school itself in order to become a lab school there is a standing committee which is a an appointed committee under the board of education and they will meet they will review they will work with the applicants through the process before the application gets to you i will share with you just a little bit of information about that group that you have already appointed it includes two board members mr hanson and mr rotherham as well as three educational and professional

[04:08:34] community members being Joan Wardiska, John Bailey and Pam Moran. At the last meeting, Ms. Wardiska was elected as the lead of that group and Ms. Moran as the deputy. So the process that the Standing Committee follows in order to process an application from their receipts to you, the very first thing is that all lab school applications do come directly to the Department of education what we do is we review it for completeness completeness means did they do

[04:09:10] everything that is in the application and there might be communication back and forth about you're missing this portion you didn't address that portion as well as completeness is are you structured in such a way that you will follow all of the legal code requirements of a school it is it should not be that a lab school application comes to you and they are asking for things that already contradict code. Once the department reviews that, then that application does get turned over to the standing committee. The standing committee reviews that lab school application,

[04:09:46] they meet with the applicant in an interview for their application, and then they provide a space of time where the public may comment on that lab school's application. Then what they will do is they will develop and provide a written report to you, the Board of Education, with recommendations based on elements in the application including all public comment for you to consider as to whether or not you as the board of education approve the startup of that lab school you are the ones who

[04:10:18] have the power to do that there is a set calendar this is a public meeting the last one did occur and the date was recent i had written down previously sorry it was about two weeks ago it was live here and that group did meet and they did discuss some of the bylaws they did discuss some of the makeup of that committee all of the dates moving forward for that committee are published here and the standing committee will meet and all and the public is welcome to come

[04:10:53] to those and as well as be able to access the department of education's youtube live stream to view all of those meetings so that everything is open and clear to the public currently the standing committee is reviewing two applications from applicants who've gone directly to the lab school application phase. James Madison University and Southside Virginia Community College have submitted their applications. So the next steps for the standing committee is that they are going

[04:11:28] to review and suggest revisions to the 2011 application document. You may very well be aware that lab schools was an initiative that was proposed in 2010 guidelines and application documents were created at that time and a significant portion of what we are operating on are those documents but as time

has passed and as code has changed and legislation has forced us there are changes being made to those documents so the standing committee will review those recommended changes and will share that um there is and and as i already showed you the planning

[04:12:05] grant application has already been included to capture more data about the applicants who they are how we can find them how we can get in touch with them etc as well as more information about their public and private industry partnerships the next step is for them to be able to write and submit a report to the board based on the current lab school applicants that are there at this time that concludes my presentation but i do wish to hand over to mr rotherham who does serve on the standing committee to share with you his report from the standing committee

[04:12:41] unless there are questions for me maybe just want to maybe andy you're going to cover this but i think it'd be helpful for the board here to maybe at the next report to also have a i like the pie chart on the planning grants but as we start moving forward into the cadence of applications and the implementation of just kind of how you see the timeline working out for over the course

[04:13:14] of the next year of when the applications would be approved and kind of so we can start maybe helpful as we start looking at what i think this might look like and the totality of what's actually going to be approved, I just think it would be helpful for us to kind of start maybe capturing the vision. This is very helpful to get the overview of the current planning grants, but I think as we, again, move forward, it would be, I think, helpful to understand how the 100 million is going to be deployed. Yes, sir. Absolutely. And with that, that does make sense because they are processing two applications, but as you know, there are 15 in the pipeline,

[04:13:54] so I think that is a very fair request, and we'll be happy to share that with you. other questions thank you dr alban that was a terrific comprehensive presentations there's not a lot uh for me to add what what is it uh shakespeare said gravity is the soul of wit i hope you know in a moment you think i'm very witty um uh so uh i do want to underscore as as uh dr alban said we elected joan wadiska who is a former member of this board um and has just done really terrific work on making sure these applications um that the application packet the information

[04:14:30] and so forth is accessible and so forth for applicants, and her leadership is terrific. And then also Pam Moran, who was really an innovative division superintendent here in Virginia, especially in Albemarle, and did some work with trying to expand options and choices for parents with labs, schools, and other kinds of pathways.

[04:14:49] So it's exciting to have her involved. I think that covered a lot of it. The big things, obviously, like this is exciting. I mean, I think they're all exciting. if you're i'm a little bit of a space nerd so i'm particularly excited about the wallops project but they're all um they're all really uh they're really exciting and the other thing we're going to start doing that i just want to call as important is any state that has a robust uh system of choice of of any of any kind with with various kinds of choice schools has an ecosystem sort of supporting them so you have communities of practice where people can come together where you can have peer-to-peer kind of work and we're going to take steps to build those communities of

[04:15:26] practice we're going to start to um just to start to build an ecosystem here because you don't sort of flick a light switch um and and suddenly start having lots of options we're gonna have to build that community and build those muscles and that is something we're also um committed to do but it's incredibly exciting if you're somebody who thinks we should have more options and more choices for

families this is i mean everything you just talked again that you guys have the report and we just went down to belabor it it's really some exciting innovative stuff and the breadth both across the commonwealth geographically and then also just the types of activities and the schools that are involved we've got you know all various kinds of institutions involved uh all different kinds of

[04:16:03] institutes of higher education including hbcus it's just all it it's all really exciting thing to see happening anybody else not thank you dr alvin very much for the presentation thank you mr rotherham and mr hansen for serving on the committee i will go back to item h first review of recommendation to approve uh new education endorsement programs dr johnson and miss torbert thank you president gecker vice president man and board members i'm before you a first review for the advisory board on teacher education and licensure's recommendation to approve new

[04:16:41] education endorsement programs the regulations governing the review and approval of education programs of virginia requires that the virginia board of education approve requests from virginia institutions of higher ed to add new endorsement programs and requests for new programs must be submitted annually. Virginia Department of Education content staff as well as staff from our office have verified program endorsement competencies through the review of course descriptions and syllabi to determine alignment with the regulatory criteria including supervised clinicals. A review of the request of the endorsement application submitted by the institution

[04:17:17] includes evidence of demand or need as well as collaboration with partners in their school divisions all requests or requirements of the applications are found in the sections provided in your overview during the recent january and february of 23 advisory board of teacher education and licensure recommended that the board grant endorsement programs the following is a list of the institutions of higher ed and the new endorsement programs a written university at early and primary education pre-k through three undergrad level hollands university elementary

[04:17:53] and pre-k through six undergrad and mary baldwin university elementary pre-k through six undergrad and randolph college science and secondary biology specifically at the graduate level and again as a reminder these institutions previously had these endorsements but are specifically requesting this now as a major in education and again finally the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board of education accept for first review app tells recommendations to approve the new endorsement programs listed before you and that is my presentation thank you dr johnson any

[04:18:29] questions from board members i think none we are happy to accept this for first review i appreciate it yeah i think that covers covers all of the uh formal presentations there are written materials and i see staffs in the room in case there are questions on any of the written reports that we We have any questions on those?

[04:18:53] Mr. President, I do have an annoying question on item J. Sorry. Item J, hang on. It was annoying yet. Oh, they'll be annoyed. I guess I'll own that. I guess the question is, who gets to judge if it's annoying, Andy? My question is simply for whoever, that report, like, it has all the cut scores that were set when the tests were adopted.

[04:19:14] Were there any subsequent changes that didn't? I wanted to make sure I was reading that chart correctly. The way. And that can also come, that can come. i need one of those mirrors up there that lets me see i'm sorry i'm so slow no you're yeah great to be here okay so mr rotherham would you ask your question my question was simply i really appreciate we asked for the the cut scores and and the chart in it

that you all everybody has in item j um is super helpful particularly because it gets at specific numbers of questions which i think is important that that is awesome so my question was simply

[04:19:52] is it it reads to me as these were when we adopted the assessments this was the scores the committees uh and then the board adopted were there any changes other than during that normal adoption process that we should be aware of um no okay great cool that's that's one that was easy yeah i promised annoying and i delivered easy thank you thank you anybody else okay that rolls us into

[04:20:22] discussion of current issues um obviously no superintendent here yet so any current issues uh about board members i do go ahead miss halton there's a few things perhaps that if they don't come up i'll bring you uh so i had uh a report a couple of things to comment on but also a a report from the virginia student councils association we do have a statewide uh council of student uh government leaders and they have an annual conference with hundreds of students participating

[04:20:59] and for 10 years now they have asked this the board of ed to come engage in a listening session with them and it was my honor this year my privilege this year to be the one who attended and uh it just the the top line is what an inspiring bunch of young people running this meeting and adding their input and working diligently with each other to build up their student government efforts across the commonwealth it was it was inspiring they had a number of topics that they addressed they had a very organized process you know a minute per person

[04:21:37] on so many minutes per topic etc but i thought i would highlight the ones that most of the students that most students chose to speak to and that were biggest flags from them to us and you won't be surprised to hear that the top of that list was student mental health quite a few students spoke to that and just said expressed the degree to which there is a sense of crisis right now around student mental health one students expressed that even student leaders such as themselves are just feeling burnout or feeling pressure

[04:22:15] have so much on their plates academically and otherwise uh several students expressed interest in in making sure we're having more counselors and counselors who aren't um only able to do administer testing and and involved in college counseling but actually be able to do mental health counseling a number a number of students said that as part of addressing mental health issues we need to address the environment that students are in they wanted to talk about the

[04:22:49] curriculum so students do learn some about student mental health in their coursework now because of standards we've adopted previously but they had suggestions for additional content in that a student spoke about school safety in particular that if we're going to do lockdown drills to not do unannounced drills unnecessarily so announce them in ahead of time or at least if you don't announce it ahead of time within i think the speaker said within one minute after the beginning of the drill that you announced this was a drill a number of students spoke to shortage issues

[04:23:28] substitute teachers teachers bus drivers they spoke to the need for better salaries to entice people into the profession. They spoke for the need to deal with the pressures teachers were feeling from constraints on what they can or cannot teach in the class. Students spoke to the issue of wanting to express their identities and express concern about parental sign-off on things like gender pronouns selection and said that some students don't feel safe at home. They spoke to environmental concerns how we can do better on environmental sustainability in our schools

[04:24:07] and they spoke a lot about school lunches you'll be pleased to hear the school lunch discussion even was very substantive it was all about how we can have more nutritious lunches but also more options for students who've got dietary constraints they're dealing with so it's all very thoughtful and very inspiring and then just i just had two other and i'll do very briefly one is i i've shared with um a number of you and with staff that uh concerned that i think it's time for us to have

[04:24:40] another update a report from the department on where we are on our special education challenges particularly in light of the information that we now have that the federal office of civil rights has raised it has has told us that while some of the issues that were on the plate have been addressed others are continuing and that they now have new issues and as i understand it some of the new issues being raised by the office of civil rights at least suggest that they may require

[04:25:15] regulatory action ie action by us rather than matters that the department can handle internally and so i i i'm just raising this up that this is we've been hearing about these issues for a long time going back to the JLARC report, which I think was 2020. And, you know, there's a lot and we hear every meeting from parents, there's a lot we can fix. And there's, excuse me, there's a lot we may not be able to fix. But the suggestion in some of these reports is there may be things that we can help improve, that we have a role to help make sure the department is fulfilling its responsibility

[04:25:54] effectively. And I just wanted to raise that up for consideration. And then finally, I just wanted to say is uh i got to attend a number of the history and social science um social studies uh public hearings as i know many of you did and just wanted to reflect on how useful they were how we heard a lot of feedback from a lot of the public um but also how inspiring they were you

[04:26:22] Even while folks were expressing frustration or concerns, crowds everywhere I was were overwhelmingly civil, despite across differences, and it felt like democracy at work. So lots of comments to share and to discuss with others on particular suggestions.

[04:26:42] There are things that, based on the public comment, I think we need to address in the January draft, and I think we can make it better. But overall, it was a rewarding experience. I think with regard to the report on special education, what I understood from yesterday was that the department or the administration was going to prepare a report for the board.

[04:27:06] I don't know, honestly, given the transition with the superintendent not coming on, I guess, for another 29 days or whatever the time frame is. And, you know, secretary, if you'd like to speak to this, you're certainly welcome to. my understanding is everybody at the administration level and within the department understands the issue and is committed to providing the board with an update and as you suggest i think the commitment is for more than just an update but if there are things that specifically need board

[04:27:41] action to highlight those and bring them forward in a prompt manner is that a fair summary of what What was that? I would simply agree with everything you just said. That's news. There you go. Mr. President, I appreciate you raising that issue.

[04:27:58] And I really hope that we can get a fulsome update. And also, but I also, I think one step further than that, I just generally feel that there's almost a systemic challenge that we're facing in the special education field at the district and state level.

[04:28:18] would really like to even have a deeper conversation about what can be done to really make sure that we're doing everything in our power and responsibility to help serve those that need it the most in many respects so i um we it just it's personal to me and i just want to make sure that we're doing everything we can to fulfill our responsibilities on this topic if i may just one of the channel one of the challenges is some of the things that the regulatory folks focus on are

[04:28:57] technical and the pervasive problem is uh the staffing issues we don't have enough special ed teachers and many many many of them are coming through provisional licensing strategies because divisions can't hire licensed qualified folks and so and the the newest person with the least training and our provisional licensing basically requires even a lower bar for special ed teachers than for other teachers because we're trying to address the vacancies but and then puts those

[04:29:31] really under prepared teachers in the most difficult circumstances that dealing with students with very severe challenges and it just it's not working i agree and i but i also think on top of that are the structural and the systemic issues um that uh are even uh as pervasive if not more pervasive of a challenge that we've got to figure out on um how best their needs are being met so president kecker yes ma'am thank you members of the board i just wanted to and thank you for raising this mrs holton miss holton um i i did want to let the board know that we are

[04:30:10] working on a written update uh so that you all stay fully informed of the ongoing uh monitoring with the office of special education programs osep um we uh we we will have that to you very soon in response to your specific question about issues that may fall under the board thank you for pointing out that this is ongoing routine monitoring that began in 2019 with regard to the to the first regulatory issue that osep has raised this board has already addressed that so that regulation has been corrected with regard to the second the department

[04:30:45] just found out about this concern in january of this year despite the fact that this monitoring began in 2019 and we were just notified in writing of it in february so we just received notification but we are already working on a plan with with jim to address that second regulatory issue but all of that will be covered in in the written materials that that you all receive dr rich i think you're suggesting this but just because actually i was going to ask for can we just get a timeline for those of us who are newer on the board this seems to be an ongoing situation that's gone back a number of years and so just like like what you were just saying like when were we notified what

[04:31:23] are the deficiencies ideally in plain english because some of that is uh um would be really helpful just so we can like because i think this is an important challenge i think as you can hear the board collectively wants to work on it but it would be really helpful for us to those of us who are newer to you know essentially not be joining a play in the third act so much absolutely yeah the the uh jlark report is a great starting point and it's very um readable the one thing i would say is that while you all are focused rightly on identifying the issues osep has focused on etc mr hanson's point about the broader pervasive issues and you know we'd love to have a robust

[04:32:03] conversation about that i think at some point even if it aren't even if they aren't items that directly relate to potential board action i mean they they may just be things that we can address in our annual report sure to the legislature or what i don't know but um you know if we have a and that whether that when that should be relative with new superintendent coming in etc i'm not saying it has to be

tomorrow sure but we ought to have a robust discussion at some point would would the best way to do that be one-on-ones or would you want to draw from public i think

[04:32:40] shouldn't it be here i mean well i'm just trying to figure out the best way to address the specific absolutely i i guess what i'm trying to get specific guidance on is do we do we base the issues that we address with the board on public comment that you all tend to receive by month to month or how would we know the specific issues related to the overall systemic concerns to come and brief the board on i think if i i would just suggest i think reaching out to us to get our individual specific concerns and then you can collectively put together maybe an agenda or an

[04:33:15] outline that's great we can uh collectively individually get back to you on to make sure we're covering what's on everybody's minds going forward but that would be my suggestion thank you very much i think i might be able to add to so yes i think i'll back up we one time had a really good presentation from jim chapman about the regulatory process and we learned about acronyms like nora and all those kinds of things we've had opportunities to have presentations with kent dickey to learn about local composite index you know and those kinds of things so i also think

[04:33:51] that you know before we we're going to have to go into the wheeze to fix some regulations but i also still think an opportunity just for the board to have a refresher on what is fape what is the least restrictive environment and and what is the role of the sea versus the lea because you know one thing that can be very frustrating for anybody anywhere is to be go taking your complaints to the wrong entity you know if you're you know to if you're in the wrong store trying to return a product that you bought somebody else you know that's going to be frustrating and that frustration can lead to anger so um like very recently the vsba sent out a policy update for its board members

[04:34:28] that just was four pages four or five pages and it just talked about special education was free appropriate public education was least restrictive environment so i think i think a context there is important because we obviously are working with the sea the state educational associate agency but but there's roles that are defined for for the leas the local education agencies so i think that kind of macro level orientation might be helpful and we might need to redo it uh later later in the summer but i think that macro level approach of what is special education what is it for who does serve, I think that might be helpful context for some of these other things. And my other point is

[04:35:08] this extension, not just on how I was pleased that even though there was passion, there was still courtesy at the public comments. I'm very pleased about that. But I just was so impressed, and I shouldn't have been because I've known some members of staff here for so many decades, so impressed with the job staff did organizing those, having them set up, the QR codes where people who maybe didn't want to talk could still submit written comments uh just the bottle of water you know just every everything was so thought through at every site it showed a tremendous amount of both planning

[04:35:43] but also it's not their first radio doing these events and so they they do them very very well so um and i think it's also just very important because it is a you look at the map it doesn't really show how many hours it is to drive across like region seven and and and so it's important for the department and the staff and us to go to different parts people come to us and come to comment but it's so important for us to go out to the to to the different um areas and so i just really thank the staff for that i think it was very well implemented i now again there's a lot of work lots of i think we've got some really good ideas that we can use to to bring improvements to

[04:36:19] the january document and and i look forward to that in the coming future but if it hadn't been so well organized and if the public in those places at least the ones i was at weren't so again passionate but courteous i i i think it was a great process and i appreciate it anybody else on that i do think any briefing we get ought to include sort of the legal landscape much as you say not just the faith but i guess the supreme court what two days ago did perez v sturgis allowing suits under the americans with disabilities act as well as ide as separate

[04:36:54] monetary damages i think we will see more suits against school divisions for inadequately educating kids i mean this is going to happen and it's part of the understanding of why the system works the way it does so uh there are you know there's been some discussion um about the retreat that's you know on our schedules and you know i had a request from the minister you know from the secretary actually to consider putting off the retreat until after the new superintendent has been here for a bit.

[04:37:31] And I don't know how the board feels about that. You know, I don't have strong feelings about it, honestly. We have not really settled on retreat topics yet, but is there any preliminary feedback on that concept?

[04:37:49] - I just, again, have not been to one yet. Maybe it'd be helpful to understand what the purpose of the retreat is. - Honestly, it has been in-depth planning. You know, at these meetings, we see a scattershot of topics come up and, you know, all of them are important.

[04:38:08] At the retreats, what we have tried to do is focus more directionally on where we're going, those things that will matter and really take longer term planning. And again, one of the topics that was retreated is, you know, the whole idea of what matters in terms of student outcomes, right?

[04:38:33] And I know there's a lot of literature on it, but again, those kinds of the focus days tend to help, you know, align the board. And I don't mean have everybody think the same thing, but to point the board in a very specific direction, which is what led then to the prescribed standards of quality, which highlighted the importance of teachers and principals and student outcomes. So like I said, I'm not lobbying one way or the other here. I'm looking for feedback on, you know, does it make sense? And this is not going to be the final decision, but because we will coordinate with

[04:39:11] the incoming superintendent before we make a final decision and get her views on what she would like. I mean, it may be she wants a day with us to talk about her, you know, what she's views as the future here? And if so, honestly, since it's on the schedule, I'd be inclined to say, yeah, let's just do that and give her the day to, you know, tell us what she wants.

[04:39:33] And having been in conversations with her, I'm sure that's the case. She is looking forward to having in-depth conversations and about the future of education in Virginia. So perhaps where we ought to leave it, I know I asked the question on the board, I'm not taking any feedback, but Mr. President, it probably makes sense to, once she settled in to do it later.

[04:39:52] I don't know what the current date is, but. - Well, as I said, I think what's gonna happen is I will sit down with or communicate with her. And if she wants it later, my gut would say, let's do it later. If she wants to hold the schedule because she wants to hit.

[04:40:09] - When does it schedule? - 18, 19, 20, and I. - I think 19, actually, right? - First day of the 18th. - That was the work session, right? then the retreat and then the board meeting the business meeting would be 19 i think almost her first day on the job yeah but whether she wants it that soon or not that's what i'm

saying is everybody sort of in concert with the idea that if the superintendent would like to have it we will do it and if she does it we will agree to put it off is that a fair yes my only hesitancy on

[04:40:44] that is so i yeah you're right i mean really what we ought to be doing is our comprehensive updating our conference plan and that we ought to wait for her to be ready for not only it also just serves as an extra day of time together essentially and are we able to do everything else that's going to be on our plate in april in the two-day meeting and that will include obviously putting the history and social studies standards to bed please god um and um and maybe accreditation accountability

[04:41:21] but if accreditation accountability it will be on first review so anyway i hope we don't need three days without i don't think we will need three days i also just don't want to be the skunk in there that the um the fact is the retreat intuitively is to be looking forward as you indicated and we're going to have um potentially three new board members coming you know on the heels of all of this and it may just be more appropriate forward looking with the new superintendent a third of the board changing to defer this but i would leave it to you mr president and to the new

[04:42:01] superintendent to make that decision mr president i similarly i think that's really it's in your purview but i think there is an end here we just ask the staff to for a whole lot of information on a whole lot of topics and if we've got this on our calendar to be together maybe we we could still use the time well and then and then appropriately uh have the new state superintendent uh do planning yeah at a later time all of that with i think miss holton's comment we have a lot on our plate at that meeting uh to get through the history standards as well and just want to make sure we've uh yesterday and today have been refreshing to not be going from eight to eight

[04:42:37] and um so thanks secretary secretary for that she insisted that i cut this meeting short but i think we need to be careful not to be also over programming ourselves on that meeting we will have other opportunities again i think where we're going to leave this is i will discuss it with the incoming superintendent uh and get some feedback there and make the decision but i just wanted you all to know what was going on there uh comprehensive plan i guess you guys will do it after the

[04:43:08] turnover and you know it ought to be done fairly quickly though it's time it's due we have a five or a six five year plan it's now it is ending now that's right and that is a statutory requirement so uh i think that's it i would like to say unless anybody has anything else you know i would like to say with regard to the public hearings on the history standards much like has been commented You know, I was in Williamsburg, James City County, and was incredibly impressed by the

[04:43:46] conduct of the public there. You know, as I mentioned previously to someone, you know, for somebody like me who just appreciates civil discourse in a public setting and believes in the public running of government, et cetera, it was just so incredibly refreshing and nice to have people of completely disparate points of you being able to address them to the, you know, to the board, if you will, through us in a very civilized and decent manner. You know, it really, it made me very, very proud of the country and how we do things. It was a very good day. I'd also like to thank those board members who

[04:44:25] covered for me. As you know, I was signed up for, I guess, five of the six hearings and due to personal circumstances, couldn't make those. I really appreciate the way you guys covered. so thank you I think yes sir just on that note and and I don't want to rehash all the debates about it but I just do we're excited Dale is here I think everyone's excited to have have a new man for but I just want to say a quick word about Soparna um just because of and I think this is some stuff that necessarily hasn't you know

gotten out uh you know she came here a lot of us have uh jobs where we have a little bit of flexibility time off and so forth Soparna just like had to

[04:45:03] take time off to be here and actually meant like she couldn't take family vacations and so forth. And that's like a pretty substantial sacrifice in the same vein of I like, like Ms. Holden said and Mr. Gecker, I find those public meetings at public home, I actually find it inspiring as well, that we live in a place where you can come and you can say that you think your public officials are totally wrong and you can do that without consequence.

[04:45:25] That's a huge blessing that many people in the world do not enjoy. And so in that same vein, like Soparna, like whether you agree with her or didn't agree with her or whatever, like I think what happened was tremendously unfortunate just in terms of encouraging people, talented people to want to show up and do these jobs.

[04:45:42] She was always prepared. I sat next to her. Copious note. She had read every item, as you all know, because there was usually questions on every item. And just the sacrifice in just watching her sort of throw herself into that at a personal cost, I just think it's something we should – I just wanted to pause, and I just think we should – she wanted to serve the citizens of the Commonwealth, and I think that is something that we should honor.

[04:46:07] Andy, I'd just like to second that. And just having sat next to her, no pressure on this, Dale, but her spiral notebooks were inspiring. I had written notes on every single topic. And I felt like I was the 3.0 kid sitting next to the valedictorian in these meetings with the amount of homework that she did.

[04:46:32] And I also just want to echo the lack of due process, frankly, the character assassination that took place. I just feel like it was an episode that I hope is not repeated again anytime soon, because she did not deserve it. She is a great community leader, mother, and should be an inspiration to all of us of her dedication to her family, her community, and improving education in the Commonwealth. So I just regret what took place.

[04:47:04] But also just would like to thank the governor for his thoughtfulness yesterday morning and speaking with us about introducing Dale to us, but also Lisa and really felt like his comments were substantive, contextual on where the state of education is in the Commonwealth and all the things that are before us.

[04:47:29] And so I just want to thank him for that and also be remiss if I didn't thank Jillian as well. I think she worked awfully hard in very challenging circumstances this last year plus. And just appreciate her service to the Commonwealth as well.

[04:47:46] I'd just like to chime in that, yes, I too regret that now we've actually had two years in a row when citizens have come forward to serve on this hardest working unpaid board in the Commonwealth and put in considerable effort, and then were not confirmed in the General Assembly.

[04:48:05] So three people last year and one person this year, and I think it's not a good thing for the board, and I hope that we're able to get back to the prior expectation. Obviously, it's in legislative hands, not our hands, but watching a citizen, a private citizen come forward As Suparna did this year and as three people did last year, willing to serve and working hard at it and having it end up this way, I agree it's unfortunate and hope we are able to get back to more normal.

[04:48:42] Secretary, Madam Secretary, happy to give you the last word today. Sitting here for two days has been positively inspirational. If there's one issue in Virginia that should be devoid of all politics, it's education.

[04:49:01] and as the person who is charged by the governor to go out and find qualified individuals to serve on these boards, I want to second the comments that have been made by all of you. And it's hard for me who cares passionately about these issues. Some of you may know I formerly served on this board and i was also on the fairfax county board of education and i also my terminal degree is in

[04:49:37] history secondary education so i've cared about these issues for a long time and for me to have opinions and have to be quiet is really hard so i wanna i wanna say that it was an exercise in restraint. But boy, the opportunity to sit back and hear the civil discourse on these incredibly important issues by people who care deeply about educating the children in Virginia has been positively inspiring. And I want to thank you, Mr. President, for your leadership of this particular

[04:50:13] body. And I want to thank all of you for being a part of, and I'm willing to say it, the hardest working non-paid board in Virginia. So on behalf of, yes, and I believe it to be true. So again, the governor just asked me to be here today simply because we don't want an empty seat here.

[04:50:40] We want continuity. We want to demonstrate that we care deeply about these issues and how much you are valued with the important work that you do. So again, I just want to say thank you. And it has been a positively inspiring two days. Secretary, thank you. I would like to correct one misimpression you may have left there, which is you were never constrained about speaking.

[04:51:06] We would have been happy to hear from you at any point during the meeting. Thank you. Again, it's very good to see you again, and thanks for being with us. All right. We are actually adjourned. I think lunch is around somewhere.